Travail, famille, patrimoine: Unpacking the unpopularity of the inheritance tax

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This project uses new survey data from France to investigate the relative unpopularity of the inheritance tax. The tax is perceived as a tax on hard working individuals rather than on the wealthy: eliciting the perceived fairness of the inheritance tax, or of a tax "on the inheritance of hard working parents" yields similar results. Self-interest and knowledge of the tax explain little variation in support. Instead, equity and efficiency concerns, and most of all, beliefs about the effect of taxes on equity and efficiency, play a much larger role. Support for the inheritance tax is not immutable: a quote highlighting the unequal distribution of inherited wealth significantly increases support; while a quote stating that the tax is an unfair tax on a lifetime of hard work backfires on the (minority) of individuals who do not fully agree with it, increasing their support for the inheritance tax. Those asymmetrical effects suggest that challenging dominant narratives can be effective to shift opinions, even on a topic as polarised as the inheritance tax.

At a time when public finances are under strain, taxes that satisfy equity concerns while causing minor economic distortions should spark enthusiasm among policymakers. In that regard, the inheritance tax is a model candidate: it taxes bequests that heirs inherit out of pure luck, which on meritocratic grounds should be deemed fair—and it weighs on wealth, which is consistently more unequally distributed than income. On the efficiency side, the literature has found that because of its one-off nature, the inheritance tax does not generate large behavioural responses (Alvaredo, Garbinti and Piketty 2017; Dherbécourt et al. 2021; Piketty, Saez and Zucman 2023; Nekoei and Seim 2023).

Despite those desirable properties, the inheritance tax has not been embraced by governments facing rising public debts: in fact, it has consistently weakened globally over the past decades, and been repealed in several countries (OECD 2021). One reason for this puzzling fact might be the unfavourable public opinion of the tax: across a range of contexts, taxing inheritance has proven unpopular (Graetz and Shapiro 2005; Masson 2023). This perceived unpopularity can plausibly constrain policymakers, and restrict the set of feasible policies.

This tension between public and expert opinion raises questions about the nature of attitudes toward inheritance taxation. Why does the public oppose a tax that, from an economist perspective, scores highly on both the equity and efficiency scale? Are they ill-informed, overoptimistic regarding their future wealth accumulation prospects, concerned about economic distortions? And which arguments are most able to shift those views?

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In this paper, I address these questions with new data collected in France through a custom survey. The survey measures a range of variables capturing many channels that have been explored in the literature as potential roots of the inheritance tax unpopularity. This approach allows me to jointly test the explanatory power of those channels.

I first set up a simple conceptual framework, decomposing individual utility into self-interest, fairness, and efficiency motives. An individual asked their opinion on the inheritance tax picks a τ^* maximising this utility, which she then compares with the current tax rate. Her support for an increase or a decreasese in the tax will depend on the difference between her preferred level, and what she perceives the current level of the tax to be—she could of course be misinformed, and wrong about what that true level is.

With this framework in mind, I decompose support for the inheritance tax, using data collected in a custom survey ran in France in Spring 2022 on a representative sample of 2,200 respondents. To put support for the inheritance tax in perspective, I also measure support for four other taxes: the fuel tax, the labour income tax, the VAT, and the capital income tax.

I first show that the inheritance tax is indeed disliked more, and more acutely than other taxes. More than half of respondents want to see the tax repealed; for the second most unpopular tax in the sample, the fuel tax, that number is only 33%. At the other end of the spectrum, we find the capital income tax, a tax that targets the top of the wealth distribution. The popularity of the capital income tax indicates that the dislike for the inheritance tax does not stem from low demand for progressive taxation.

That conclusion is strengthened by another result: when part of the sample is additionally asked about taxing the bequests of *wealthy parents who have themselves inherited*, those participants perceive the tax as much more fair than the baseline. When another subgroup is instead asked the fairness of taxing the bequest of *wealthy parents who have worked hard and saved a lot*, perceived fairness is slightly higher than at the baseline. Those results suggest that respondents think of the inheritance tax "by default" not as a tax targeting wealthy individuals who have themselves inherited.

Taking the conceptual framework to the data, I regress support for the inheritance tax on four groups of variables: self-interest, equity perceptions, efficiency perceptions, and factual knowledge. An R^2 decomposition shows that self-interest explains little variation in support overall; participants who don't expect to receive a bequest, for example, are not more supportive of the inheritance tax than those who do, ceteris paribus. Knowledge also has only marginal explanatory power; participants who believe that there is no exemption threshold (the exemption threshold is actually EUR 100,000 for a transmission from a parent to a child) are not significantly more opposed to the tax than those who know that part of the bequest is exempt.

Fairness weighs more than efficiency considerations, a finding consistent with the demand for redistribution literature. Two variables in particular have considerable explanatory power: those capturing participants' beliefs about the *effect* of taxes, namely, whether taxes mostly enhance fairness, or cause distortions. A dummy equal to one if the participant has answered "enhance fairness" to the question "Do you believe that taxes mostly enhance fairness, distort economic behaviours, both, or neither?", explains 28% of the explained variation in support for the inheritance tax.

This exercise highlights the importance of beliefs about the impact of taxes in determining demand for redistribution. Low support for taxes may very well coexist with outrage about inequalities if individuals do not believe that taxes can curb inequalities. This seems to be especially the case for the inheritance tax, perceived to be a tax on hard working individuals, and not on the wealthy.

To what extent can those perceptions be shifted? To address this question, I set up an experimental design and measure the effect on support for the inheritance tax of exposing participants to two quotes, picked to be reflective of the inheritance tax debate. In the first treatment group, before support for the inheritance tax is measured, participants are exposed to a quote by Thomas Piketty that highlights the acuteness of wealth inequality, in particular of inherited wealth[2]. In the second, they are exposed to a quote by Nicolas Sarkozy, that argues that hardworking families have an inalienable right to transmission and shouldn't be penalised by inheritance taxation[3]. The quotes are not attributed to their authors, but to a "French public figure", and participants are asked how much they agree with the quote, on a 4-point scale going from "Not at all" to "Fully".

The Sarkozy quote is more consensual than the Piketty quote: two thirds of the Sarkozy treatment group agree "Fully" with the quote; that share is one third in the Piketty group. Turning to treatment effects on support, I find that the Piketty quote increases support for the inheritance tax, by .2 standard deviations[4]. The Sarkozy quote on the other hand does not have a significant effect on support for the inheritance tax; if anything, the point estimate appears to be positive, contrary to the model's prediction. Both quotes also significantly increase support for the capital income tax; the most popular tax in the sample.

To understand the mechanisms behind those effects, I explore three sources of heterogeneity. I start by interacting the treatments with political affiliation, and find that the positive effect of the Piketty quote is driven by left-wing and centrist participants. The small positive effect of the Sarkozy quote also seems to come from left-wing and centrist participants. On a topic as politically polarised as the inheritance tax, those results are indicative of partisan reasoning.

Second, I look at heterogeneity by agreement with the treatment quote. The effects are asymmetrical: people who fully agree with the Piketty quote do display a stronger treatment effect, but the effect is also positive (although significant only at the 10% level) for participants who don't. The Sarkozy quote on the other hand has no effect on those who fully agree with it, but a clear, positive effect on those who do not fully agree with it, comparable in size to the effect of the Piketty quote. Those who fully agree with the Sarkozy quote are also much more opposed to the tax at the baseline. The quote backfires: it increases support among participants who do not fully agree with it.

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[2]The full quote reads: "Inheritance equality is nothing demagogical [...] We live in a society where 50% of the population inherits nothing, or almost nothing: the poorest half receives 5,000 or 10,000 euros, and often very late in life. This is the great limit of all social democracies up to now: in our system, the poorest 50% have nothing, and this is true for all age groups, and always has been. Never in history have the bottom 50% owned more than 10% of the capital."

[3]The full quote reads: "Family is by definition the place of transmission. When they've worked hard and paid their taxes, why should families be forbidden to pass on to their children the fruits of a whole generation's labour? What is more beautiful than wanting your children to start slightly better off than you started yourself?"

[4]This effect size is comparable to similar papers, such as Stantcheva (2021).

Finally, I study heterogeneous effects by words used by participants in an open-ended question asked before the treatment. I define a set of 'Piketty words' and 'Sarkozy words', echoing the volcabulary and theme used in each of the two quotes. I find that the Piketty treatment effect is larger on Piketty word users; and that there is a negative treatment effect of the Sarkozy quote on Sarkozy word users. This evidence further suggests that arguments about the inheritance tax mostly convinces those predisposed to agree with them.

In summary, the Piketty narrative is less ubiquitous than the Sarkozy one, and while more persuasive for individuals who agree with it, it does to an extent convince its opponents—perhaps because they had not thought, or did not know, about the starkness of inherited wealth inequality. The Sarkozy narrative does not affect the support of its partisans, potentially because the quote already exactly reflects their opinion, and because many of them already display very low levels of support for the tax. It however backfires on its opponents, making them more favourable to the tax; potentially because they are exasperated by it.

Related literature. The present paper builds on a rapidly growing literature using custom surveys to study attitudes towards redistributive policies. It is closely related to Stantcheva (2021), who looks at the way people reason about the income and the estate tax in the US, and shows fairness rather than efficiency concerns to be decisive; Almås, Cappelen and Tungodden (2020) reach a similar conclusion in their analysis of differences in inequality acceptance between the US and Sweden. Bastani and Waldenström (2021) look at the effect of informing respondents about the salience of inherited wealth in Sweden, and show an increase in support for an inheritance tax[5]. Similarly, Kuziemko et al. (2015) show that informing respondents about the true number of estates subject to the estate tax in the US massively increases support for it; but that other policy preferences are much harder to move. Sides (2016) echoes that last finding, and finds that providing respondents with factual information about how many American estates pay the estate tax is more succesfull at moving preferences than "emotional" or stories-based arguments. Alesina, Stantcheva and Teso (2018) look at the role of beliefs about mobility in an international context, showing that a treatment making respondent more pessimistic about mobility does not have much of an impact on respondents. Fisman et al. (2020) directly address the political feasibility of taxation by mapping individual preferred tax rate jointly over income and wealth; they show that preferred wealth schedule depends on whether wealth has been accumulated through one's own savings or via a bequest.

The experimental section of the paper is also linked to a political science literature studying persuasion and motivated reasoning in the formation of political beliefs. A large literature building on Zaller (1992) has shown that individuals are more easily persuaded by arguments made by their political party and allies, and discount arguments that are contrary to their attitudes, especially when those are strongly held and tightly linked to political identification (Leeper and Slothuus 2014). This is echoed in Alesina, Stantcheva and Teso (2018) for example, who find that pushing respondents to be more pessimistic about social mobility only increases support for redistribution among left-wing respondents. A small number of papers have documented the existence of resistance, or "backfiring" effects: when an argument has the opposite effect to that intended, because of excessive distance between one's prior attitude and the position advocated in the message — Fatemi, Hasseldine and Hite (2008) shows that a positive framing of the es-

[5] Sweden's inheritance tax was repealed in 2004.

tate tax decreases support among those who oppose the tax the most, and Baarck, Dolls and Windsteiger (2026)

Institutional context. The inheritance tax in France is characterised by a) relatively high marginal rates, b) stark differences in tax regimes depending on the relationship between the donor and the receiver and c) a large number of exemptions disproportionately favouring the very top of the bequest distribution (Biernat et al. 2021). It is levied on the recipient of wealth transfers, rather than on the estate. In 2019, tax revenue generated by inheritance taxation in France (1.4% of total tax revenue) was among the highest in OECD countries, surpassed only by Belgium and Korea (OECD 2021).

French tax law defines seven beneficiary groups according to their relationship with the donor; those groups face different exemption thresholds and rate schedules[6]. For a parent leaving a bequest to a child, a deduction of EUR 100,000 applies, and marginal rates then rise from 5 to 45%; between spouses, no tax has to be paid at all. As shown in Figure A1 in Appendix, for other types of donor-receiver relationships, marginal tax rates rise fast; as a result, though they represent less than 10% of total capital transferred, bequests and donations to collateral heirs[7] generate over 50% of total tax revenue derived from inheritance and donation taxation (Dherbécourt et al. 2021).

The tax also features numerous exemptions for certain types of assets, which disproportionately advantage the top of the inheritance distribution. To mention but a few, professional assets benefit from a 75%, uncapped deduction, life insurance is favourably taxed, and unrealised capital gains are fully exempt from inheritance tax. Finally, transfer taxes "reset" every 15 years (i.e. heirs who received a donation more than 15 years prior to receiveing a bequest still benefit from the EUR100,000 deduction), allowing organised families to effectively transfer much more than EUR100,000 per parent and per child tax free.

1 Survey data and treatment design

Between April and May 2022, I ran a randomised survey experiment on about 2,500 French respondents. The survey was written in Qualtrics, and sent to participants by survey distribution company Bilendi (formerly Respondi). Participants are enrolled in the company's panel and are paid to take surveys depending on their length and complexity. In this case, each participant received £2 for completing the survey.

1.1 Survey structure

The survey structure is summarised in Figure 1. The detailed structure and full questionnaire translated in English are provided in Appendix B and **??**, respectively. After completing the demographics section, participants answer the open-ended question, which reads "The inheritance tax, also called "succession duty" is a tax collected by the state on the transfer of wealth from a deceased person to their heirs. Can you describe in a few sentences what this tax brings to your mind?". Then, if they belong to one of the treatment group, they are shown the corresponding quote—if they are in the control group, they are not shown anything at this stage. They then

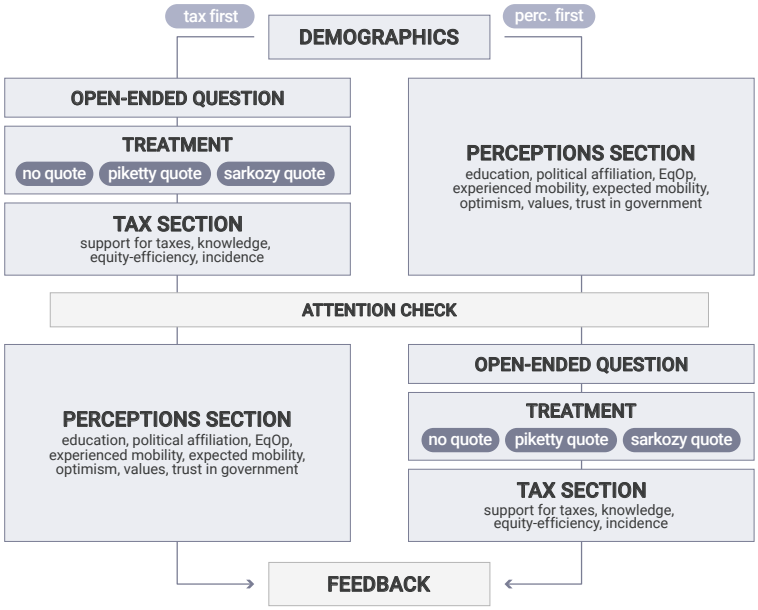
[6]From the most to the least favourably taxed, those groups are: 1) spouse, 2) children, stepchildren, parents and grandparents, 3) grandchildren, 4) siblings, 5) nieces and nephews, 6) aunts, uncles, cousins and distant family members, 7) children in law, parents in law, and unrelated parties

[7]That is, to heirs other than spouses, parents, children, grandparents or grandchildren.

move on to the Tax Section, which includes questions about support for the inheritance tax and for other taxes, and a series of questions pertaining to the tax (namely their knowledge of the tax, their perceptions of behavioural responses, and whether they expect to or have already paid the tax).

They are then asked an attention check question and move on to the Perceptions Section, measuring attitudes and beliefs that are not directly related to the inheritance tax, but could contribute to explaining variation in support (political behaviour, beliefs about equality of opportunity, social mobility, values, and trust in government). Lastly, they have the opportunity to leave feedback on the survey. The order was inverted for half the participants, who were first shown the Perceptions section, followed by the open-ended question, treatment, and Tax section after the attention check.

Figure 1: Structure of the survey



Notes: This diagram summarises the structure of the survey. There are two axes of randomisation: respondents are either presented with the open-ended question, the treatment, and the Tax section first, or with the Perceptions section first. Then, participants are randomised into either the control group, the Piketty quote treatment group, or the Sarkozy quote treatment group.

Main outcome variables. After answering the open-ended question and possibly reading a treatment quote (the treatment design is presented in detail in Section 1.2 below), participants are asked about their support for the inheritance tax and for other taxes. Specifically, they first see three questions asking them about the inheritance tax: (Support) How would you describe your support for the inheritance tax as it currently exists in France? [Completely oppose - Completely support]; (Fairness) How fair do you deem the inheritance tax? [Completely unfair - Completely fair]; and (Preferred level) In your opinion, compared to its current level in France, the inheritance tax should ideally be: [Repealed - Much higher]).

The next two questions show participants a matrix where support for the inheritance tax is measured together with four other taxes (the labour income tax, capital income tax, VAT, and fuel tax). The first question asks them to rate the fairness of each tax (Matrix Fairness: How fair do you think it is to tax the following resources? [Completely unfair - Completely fair]), and

the second is about each tax ideal level (Matrix Preferred level: In your opinion, what should be the level of the following taxes, compared to their current level in France? [Repealed - Much higher]).

Lastly, they are asked one (randomly assigned) additional version of the Fairness question, which is either one of the following: (Fairness inherited) Is it fair or unfair that wealthy parents who have inherited a large estate from their parents are subject to the inheritance tax?; and (Fairness worked hard) Is it fair or unfair that wealthy parents who have worked hard and saved a lot to pass on their wealth to their children are subject to the inheritance tax?. Answers to both questions range from Completely unfair to Completely fair on a 5-point Likert scale.

1.2 Treatment design

Participants are randomly assigned to one of three equally sized groups:

(1) Control group, where they are taken to the Tax section immediately after answering the open-ended question.

(2) Treatment group 1, where after the open-ended question but before the Tax section, they are exposed to an anonymised quote by Thomas Piketty[8] stressing the inequality of the wealth and inheritance distribution:

> *"Inheritance equality is nothing demagogical [...] We live in a society where 50% of the population inherits nothing, or almost nothing: the poorest half receives 5,000 or 10,000 euros, and often very late in life. This is the great limit of all social democracies up to now: in our system, the poorest 50% have nothing, and this is true for all age groups, and always has been. Never in history have the bottom 50% owned more than 10% of the capital."*

(3) Treatment group 2, where they are exposed to an anonymised quote by Nicolas Sarkozy[9] insisting on the importance of family and the value of intergenerational transmission:

> *"Family is by definition the place of transmission. When they've worked hard and paid their taxes, why should families be forbidden to pass on to their children the fruits of a whole generation's labour? What is more beautiful than wanting your children to start slightly better off than you started yourself?"*

In both treatment groups, participants are shown the quote without reference to their author, with the heading: "Here is a quote by a French public figure about inheritance". Below, they were asked: "To what extent does this quote reflect your opinion?" and had to reply on a 1-4 Likert scale, from "Absolutely not" to "Fully". Figure A2 shows the appearance of the treatment in the survey.

The quotes are picked to reflect the debate on the inheritance tax in France. Thomas Piketty's quote expected effect is to increase support for inheritance taxation. Participants learn or are reminded about the severity of wealth inequality; if they are convinced that this level of inequality is undesirable, and believe that inheritance taxation is a good way to curb inequality, they will support it more. The quote includes numbers quantifying inequality – it provides both factual

[8] Thomas Piketty is a French economist whose work focuses namely on the long-run dynamics of income and wealth inequality and on the distributional role of political institutions. The quote is taken from an interview given to *Libération* and published on 11 September 2019, available here.

[9] Nicolas Sarkozy was the French president from 2007 to 2012. He was the leader at the time of the right-wing party *Union pour un Mouvement Populaire*, since renamed *Les Républicains*. The quote is taken from a speech given in Lavaur on 7 February 2012, available here.

information (50% of the population inherits nothing) and a value judgement ("the great limit of all social democracies").

The expected effect of Nicolas Sarkozy's quote is instead to decrease support for inheritance taxation. It celebrates the hard work of families and the transmission of those efforts' fruits, hence if participants are receptive to those values, they will be pushed to believe that inheritance taxation is unfair, since it deprives families of legitimate estates they have worked hard for. This quote contains a value judgement, but no factual information.

Let us finally note that although both quotes are anonymised, they do belong to well-defined political currents. It is therefore possible that some participants recognise them as characteristic of those currents and react as they would to "typical leftist/rightist discourse" rather than to their actual content. This is not undesirable: first because it is in any case difficult to produce a politically neutral statement on the topic of inequality and redistribution[10], and second because such mechanisms would also be at play in a real life, when participants read the news or listen to a political debate — thus it informs our research question. Obviously, in real life, the quotes wouldn't be anonymous; but they could have come from various actors (politicians, journalists, researchers), whom participants could know or not know, and importantly, could like or dislike. Here, by not disclosing the authors' identity, I attempt to "average out" emitter-specific effects on policy preferences.

1.3 Sample restrictions, data quality, and balance

1.3.1 Sample restrictions

I impose restrictions on the main sample to make sure to keep only reasonably attentive respondents. I start by dropping individuals who did not answer the main questions measuring support for the inheritance tax. A handful of individuals have filled in the survey more than once; I keep their first participation. This baseline sample consists of 2,521 individuals.

I also aim to identify and drop the participants who filled the survey carelessly: they are a source of noise and risk taming potential treatment effects. The survey included an attention check question (a "trap" question directing respondents to reply in a certain way); this question was perhaps too challenging as a third of the sample failed. Failing to pass the attention check matters: those who did are significantly more likely to "support" the inheritance tax controlling for baseline covariates, as shown in Table A1 Panel A — most likely because the distribution of support is extremely skewed, and unattentive respondents tend to select "middle" answers.

To avoid dropping too many respondents, I do not exclude all those who failed, but only drop respondents if they failed the attention check *and* were flagged as speeders. Respondents are flagged as speeders if they are below the 5th percentile of time spent answering the whole survey, the Perceptions section, the Tax section, or the main question about support for the inheritance tax[11]. Table A1 Panel B shows that after dropping those speeders, failing the attention check is not longer associated with significantly higher support for the inheritance tax.

[10] Informational treatments are no exception. Bastani and Waldenström (2021) for example tell treated participants that "A majority of Swedish billionaires have inherited their fortunes"; although this is a purely positive statement, it could still be argued that it belongs more to the realm of the political left than the right.

[11] The 5th percentile is computed among respondents who passed the attention check, and within treatment group. Those tresholds are around 8:30 minutes for the full survey, 1:30 minutes for the Perceptions section, 1:21 minutes for the Tax section, and 12 seconds for the main outcome question.

This sample of 2,211 respondents constitutes the main sample.

1.3.2 Attrition, effort and perceived bias

Respondents were able to skip questions, apart from the initial mandatory consent form. If they attempted to move to the next page having omitted N questions, they received the following message: "There are N unanswered questions on this page. Would you like to continue?" with two options: "Continue without answering" and "Answer the questions". This gives participants a way out should they wish not to answer a question, but prevents skipping being entirely costless.

Despite this, most questions in the final sample had a very high response rate; even sensitive questions such as net household wealth or political affiliation only had respectively 1 and 5% of non-answers. Attrition was low as well; in the unrestricted sample, only 8% of participants who opened the survey stopped answering questions before the end of the questionnaire.

The open-ended question is a good way to measure the effort put in by participants: typing an answer is costlier than selecting one in a multiple-choice setting; and just like other questions, participants could choose to leave it blank. Less than 3% of participants did not write anything, and 93% wrote 5 characters or more. Figure **??** in Appendix shows the distribution of answers length. The median answer was 38 characters long[12].

Finally, participants were asked at the very end of the questionnaire whether they felt the survey was politically biased. An large majority (83.1%) perceived it as unbiased; among those who did view it as biased, slightly more respondents said that it was right-wing biased (10.2%) rather than left-wing biased (6.7%, see distribution in Figure A4).

1.3.3 Representativity and balance

Table A2 displays the mean value of some key demographics in the sample in comparison with the French population. The sample is representative of the French population overall, although respondents tend to be lower income and higher education on average. This is not uncommon in this type of surveys. Note that those categories are all controlled for throughout the analysis.

Table A3 shows the mean value of key demographics in the control, the Piketty and the Sarkozy treatment group. Balance is achieved overall, to the exception of education: there are less university graduates in the control groups (46%) than in the two treatment groups (52%). There are also slightly more individuals with siblings in the Piketty treatment group. This difference is not driven by the sample selection described in Section 1.3.1, since the same is true of the fully unrestricted sample (see Appendix Table A4); hence to the best of my knowledge, this imbalance is due to chance. It does imply that including controls for education level will be crucial when computing treatment effects, since this paper confirms the well-documented finding that higher education individuals support taxes more.

2 Conceptual framework

When an individual is asked their opinion on the inheritance tax, they pick a tax rate τ that maximises their overall utility U_i, which is split in three components: self-interest (capturing the effect of the tax on their lifetime budget constraint), fairness and equity (capturing the tax'

[12] An example of such a median-length answer is: "A widespread and unacceptable injustice"

impact on fairness and equity in the economy, relative to their preferred equity level), and distortions (capturing the inefficiency costs generated by the tax, through behavioural responses and government inefficiency). They solve the following maximisation problem:

$$\max_{\tau} U_i = \underbrace{u(c_{it}, (1-\tau)\mathbb{E}b_{it+1})}_{\text{self-interest}} - \underbrace{\delta_i(q_i(\tau) - q_i^*)^2}_{\text{fairness and equity}} - \underbrace{\gamma_i(k_i(\tau))^2}_{\text{distortive effects}} \quad (1)$$

where

$$c_{it} = \alpha_i(w_{it} + \tau\bar{b}_t + (1-\tau)b_{it})$$
$$b_{it+1} = (1-\alpha_i)(w_{it} + \tau\bar{b}_t + (1-\tau)b_{it})$$

c_{it} is lifetime consumption, w_{it} is labour income, b_{it}, b_{it+1} the bequest they receive and leave, respectively, and $\bar{b}_{it}$ the average bequest left in the economy. q_i^* is a vector capturing their preferred equity level. $q_i(\tau)$ and $k_i(\tau)$ are vectors of the perceptions of the current level of equity/distortions, and capture the way the individual believes they depend on τ. δ_i and γ_i are the weights put by the individual on Fairness and Distortions considerations in picking her preferred τ, relative to self-interest. Because the aim of the model is to analyse perceptions rather than real economic decisions, I simplify the intertemporal consumption choice to a split of lifetime resources between a share α_i devoted to consumption, and a share $(1-\alpha_i)$ allocated to a bequest.

Once the individual has determined her preferred τ, she compares that rate to her perception of the current tax rate. Her answer of the question of the type "Should the inheritance tax be increased or decreased?" will then depend on $\tau^* - \hat{\tau}$, where $\tau^* = argmax_\tau U_i(\tau)$, and $\hat{\tau}$ is her perception of the true tax rate, τ^{true}; of course, the two could be far apart if the individual is misinformed. Noting misinformation about the tax η_i (where higher values of η_i mean that the individual overestimates the level of the tax), their answer depends on $\tau^* - (\tau^{\text{true}} + \eta_i)$.

Before we set the FOC, note that

$$\frac{dc_{it}}{d\tau} = \alpha_i(\bar{b}_t - b_{it}) \quad \text{and} \quad \frac{d(1-\tau)b_{it+1}}{d\tau} = (1-\alpha_i)(-w_{it} + (1-2\tau)\bar{b}_t - 2(1-\tau)b_{it})$$

that is:

- c_{it} is increasing in τ if the individual receives a bequest smaller than average, decreasing otherwise;
- $(1-\tau)b_{it+1}$ is generally decreasing in τ, except if $\tau < 1 - \frac{\bar{b}_t + w_{it}}{2(\bar{b}_t - b_{it})}$. As $0 \leq \tau \leq 1$, the inequality can only be satisfied if individual i receives a bequest much lower than the average individual, as well as a relatively low wage: it must be that $w_{it} + 2b_{it} < \bar{b}_t$, i.e. her labour income plus twice the bequest she received is below the average bequest received in the economy.

The FOC is:

$$u_c(.)\frac{dc_{it}}{d\tau} + u_b(.)\frac{d(1-\tau)b_{it+1}}{d\tau} + 2\delta_i(q_i^* - q_i(\tau))q_{i\tau} = 2\gamma_i k_i(\tau)k_{i\tau} \quad (2)$$

The FOC highlights the fact that equity and efficiency components are the product of two distinct elements: how concerned the individual is about equity/efficiency ($\delta_i(q_i^* - q_i(\tau))$ and $\gamma_i(k_i(\tau))$),

and how much they believe taxes affect equity/efficiency ($q_{i\tau}$ and $k_{i\tau}$). For concern about equity for example to translate into demand for taxation, the individual must believe that those derivatives are non-zero.

3 Determinants and decomposition of support for the inheritance tax

This section looks at the level and determinants of support for the inheritance tax and for four other taxes (the labour income tax, capital income tax, VAT, and fuel tax) in the control group.

3.1 Support for the inheritance and other main taxes

Figure 2 plots average support for the inheritance tax along with the other main outcome variables. Panel A displays the (unstandardised) average of the Matrix fairness and Matrix preferred level questions for each tax. Both questions offer answers ranging from 1 to 7. Panel B shows the share of respondents who are not "radically opposed" to each tax; that is, who did not pick the most negative option (1 out of 7 on the Likert scale) for both the Matrix fairness and Matrix preferred level question. Figure A6 in Appendix shows the distribution of answers for each individual outcome variable; for each question, the mode is the most negative answer. Those variables are all positively correlated, with correlation coefficients ranging between .62 and .83, as shown in Appendix Table A5. Hence most respondents who do not support the tax also find it unfair and find its level excessive.

This suggests that the inheritance tax is unpopular both in absolute and in relative terms: it is the most unpopular of the five taxes according to both measures. It appears not only to garner more opposition than other taxes, but also a more radical opposition: although average support for the fuel tax[13] looks comparable to the inheritance tax, the share of those who report the most negative opinion possible is 20 percentage point higher for the inheritance tax.

The fuel tax follows as the second most unpopular tax, then the labour income tax, VAT, and capital income tax. It is striking how popular the capital income tax is compared to other taxes: 32% of respondents in the control group think that it is somewhat fair, fair, or completely fair, and 27% that it should be somewhat higher, higher, or much higher than it currently is. Those numbers are only 15% and 6% respectively for the VAT, the second most popular tax.

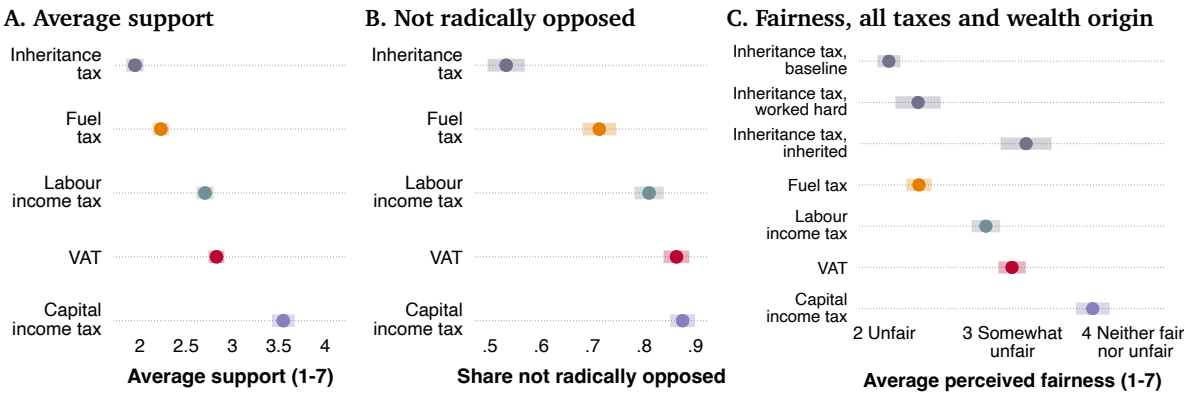
Fairness perceptions by origin of parents' wealth. How does the perceived fairness of the inheritance tax vary when telling respondents about the origin of parents' wealth? Each participant is asked one alternative version of the Fairness question: whether it is fair to tax the bequests left either by wealthy parents who have themselves inherited a large estate (Fairness inherited), or by wealthy parents who have worked hard to pass on wealth to their children (Fairness worked hard).

Figure 2 Panel C shows that taxing wealthy parents who have themselves inherited is perceived as much fairer than the baseline: while less than 4% of respondents believe that the inheritance tax is fair or completely fair, that number increases to 21% in the case of parents who have inherited a large estate[14]. This result is in line with the literature showing that there is higher

[13] The fuel tax is a particularly unpopular and politically charged tax in France; its planned increase contributed to spurring the first *Gilets Jaunes* protest in November 2018.

[14] Note that the mode is still the "Completely unfair" option—see the distribution of each variable in Figure A7.

Figure 2: Support for all main taxes and perceived fairness by origin of parents' wealth



Notes: Panel A shows the average of the Matrix Fairness (Do you think it is fair to tax [resource]?) and Matrix Level (In your opinion, what should be the level of [tax], compared to its current level in France?) questions for each tax in the control group (N=756). The questions were answered on a 1 to 7 scale, 4 being the neutral option. Panel B shows the share of respondents "Not radically opposed", that is, all respondents who didn't choose the most negative answer (1 on the Likert scale) to both the Matrix Fairness and the Matrix Level questions. 95% confidence intervals are displayed.

willingness to tax wealth earned through luck rather than effort (see Fisman et al. 2020); and that ceteris paribus, a tax that targets the wealthy is more popular than one that doesn't[15].

On the other hand, participants perceive a tax on the bequests of wealthy parents who have worked hard as slightly *more fair* ($p = .026$) than the baseline. This suggests that when asked about the inheritance tax without further details, participants think of a tax borne by hardworking parents rather than by parents who have themselves inherited; and that they do not think of particularly wealthy parents. We can go further: comparing the distribution of the baseline Fairness question to Fairness worked hard, pictured in Figure A7, shows that the latter is more polarised[16]. This pattern could be explained by the opposing effects on perceived fairness of describing parents as "wealthy" on the one hand, and as having "worked hard" on the other hand. If the former is more salient or decisive for respondents, they may increase their fairness rating, because they believe that an inheritance tax on the wealthy is fairer than the baseline. If instead the latter is key, they are likely to decrease their fairness rating, because they believe that taxing hardworking people is unfair.

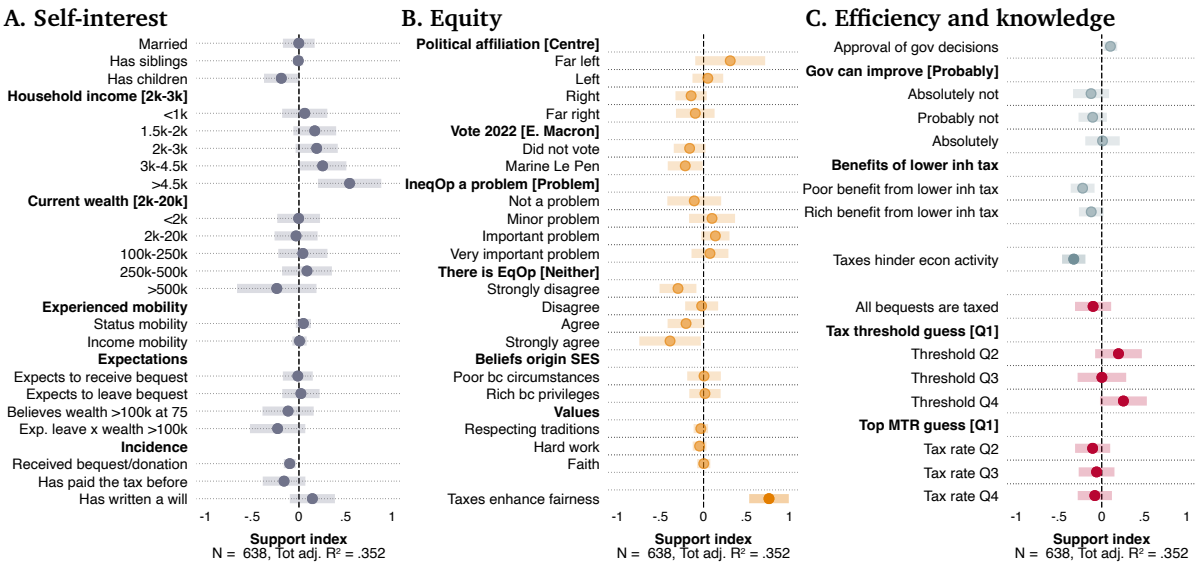
3.2 Determinants of support and R square decomposition

How much variation in support for the inheritance tax can we explain? This section explores determinants of support in the control group. Figure 3 Panel A displays the results of an OLS regression of the standardised support index defined in Section 3.1 on a large set of controls corresponding to the components defined in the conceptual framework: Self interest, Equity, Efficiency, and Knowledge. This evidence is to be interpreted together with Figure 4 which displays the Shapley value of the R^2 contribution of each component.

[15] See namely Bastani and Waldenström (2021), where there is significantly more support for a high-exemption threshold inheritance tax than a low-threshold one; and Kuziemko et al. (2015), where participants' support for the estate tax increases by a very large amount when they learn the small number of estates wealthy enough to be subject to the inheritance tax

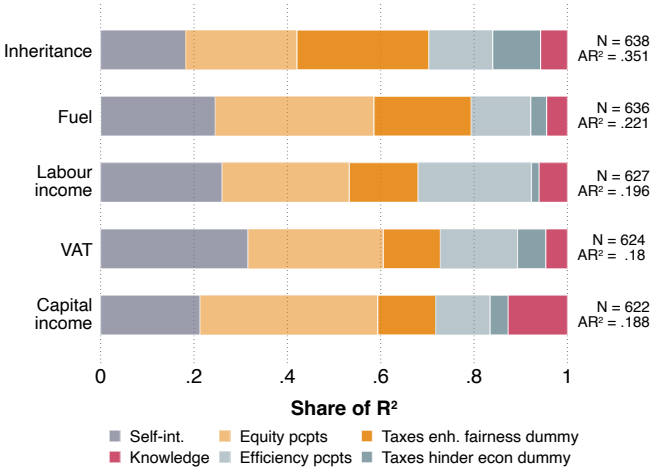
[16] 59% of respondents give the same answer to the Fairness and the Fairness worked hard questions. 19% (resp. 22%) rate Fairness worked hard as less fair (resp. fairer) than the baseline.

Figure 3: Regression of support for the inheritance tax



Notes: The graph plots coefficients from an OLS regression of the support index for the inheritance tax on the full set of controls. The three panels correspond to a single regression including all covariates at once. The regression also includes controls for gender, age, education, region of residence, and work status, not reported.

Figure 4: R^2 decomposition of support for taxes



Notes: Each row displays the R^2 decomposition of support for the corresponding tax, in six groups of variables: Self-interest, Equity perceptions, Effect of taxes on equity, Efficiency perceptions, Effect of taxes on efficiency, and Knowledge. The R^2 contributions are the Shapley values. The sample size and adjusted R^2 are reported at the end of each row.

Self-interest. Figure 3 Panel A shows that self-interest does explain some of the variation in support for the inheritance tax; but that a lot of the coefficients are small. Having children and expecting to leave a bequest interacted with expecting to have more than €100k in wealth by age 75 are associated with lower support. Expecting to receive a bequest however, has a relatively precise zero coefficient. The wealth gradient is also very flat up until the wealthiest category, which appears to oppose the tax more. The income gradient is positive. All these variables together explain a relatively modest share (18%) of the total explained variance.

Equity. The equity component is split in two: equity perceptions on the one hand (proxied by political affiliation and voting behaviour, beliefs about inequality of opportunity, about the reasons for people to be rich/poor, and values), and the effect of taxes on equity on the other hand. The latter is a dummy equal to one if the participant has answered "enhance fairness" to the question "Do you believe that taxes mostly enhance fairness, distort economic behaviours, both, or neither?". It is immediately striking that this single variable is associated with a much larger coefficient than any other variable in the regression; it also explains 28% of the total explained variation, as shown in Figure 4.

Equity perceptions on the other hand explain about 24%. The coefficients on the equity perceptions variables are more muted. Far left participants are more favourable to the tax, although the category is small and the coefficient somewhat imprecise. Right-wing respondents and those who did not vote for Emmanuel Macron are less favourable. The equality of opportunity variable are associated with support non-linearly: those who believe that inequality of opportunity is a "very important" problem do not support the tax more than those who think it is an "important" problem. Those who strongly disagree *and* those who strongly agree that there is equality of opportunity in France are both less supportive of the tax than participants who have more moderate opinions.

Overall, the equity component explains more than half of the total explained variation; and a key role is played by the perceptions participants have of the effect of taxes on equity, rather than their perceptions of existing inequity.

Efficiency. The efficiency component includes variables related to potential trickle down effects (if the inheritance tax were to decrease, would the poorest/the richest benefit or be harmed) and of government efficiency (an index summarising approval of decisions taken by the government, and a question about whether the government is able to improve economic conditions). Similar to the equity component, the effect of taxes on efficiency is captured by a dummy equal to one if the participant has answered "Hinder" to the question "Do you believe that a higher inheritance tax would encourage, hinder, or not affect economic activity?".

Once again, the "effect of taxes" variable is associated with a significant and relatively large coefficient, although less so than for the equity component. This dummy accounts for 10% of the total R^2. Approval of government decisions is positively associated with support for the tax: a one standard deviation increase in approval corresponds to a .1 standard deviation increase in support. Trust in the ability of the government to improve economic conditions is not significantly associated with support. The belief in trickle down effects (that the poorest could benefit from a decrease in the inheritance tax) is linked to lower support for the tax; however, the belief that the *richest* would benefit is also associated with lower support ($p = .094$).

The efficiency component explains 23% of the total explained variation. Once again, a significant chunk of that share comes from the "effect of taxes" variable.

Knowledge. Finally, the knowledge component consists of three questions: are all bequests taxed, or only bequests above a certain threshold (the latter is true), how much is that threshold (EUR 100,000), and how much is the top marginal tax rate (45%). Interestingly, participants who believe that all bequests are subject to the inheritance tax do *not* show lower support for the tax; and the top marginal tax rate perception does not seem to play a significant role. Finally, participants who think that the exemption threshold is high (Q4 corresponds to guesses of EUR

150,000 and more) support the tax more, but the effect is not linear across quartiles. Knowledge represents a modest share of the overall R^2, about 6%.

In conclusion, self-interest explains relatively little variation in support overall, knowledge has only marginal explanatory power, equity weighs more than efficiency considerations (a consistent finding in the demand for redistribution literature), and the two "effect of taxes" dummies have considerable explanatory power.

The R^2 decomposition for the other taxes is also depicted in Figure 4. Those results are useful as a comparison, but should be taken with a grain of salt, since the same set of covariates is used as for the inheritance tax regression, and many variables are specific to the inheritance tax[17]. Those limitations in mind, the decompositions suggest that equity concerns also play a major role in determining support for other taxes, although that is particularly true for the inheritance tax. Efficiency concerns also matter, roughly as much as self-interest for most taxes. Knowledge seems to play less of a role, except for the capital income tax. The "Enhance fairness" dummy alone consistently explains a sizeable share of the overall variation, although that is again particularly true of the inheritance tax. Each tax' full regression is reported in Figures A10 to A13.

This exercise completes the plotting of the raw means, and shows that beyond self-interest and beliefs about equity and efficienci, beliefs about the *effects* of taxes matter a lot for demand for redistribution. A lot of the seemingly low support for taxes may coexist with outrage about inequalities if individuals do not believe that taxes can curb inequalities. This seems to be especially the case for the inheritance tax, perceived to be a tax on hard working and not particularly wealthy individuals.

4 Treatment effects of the quotes

To what extent can those perceptions be shifted, and what type of argument is more persuasive? To address this question, I leverage the experimental design described in Section 1.2 and measure the effect on support for the inheritance tax of exposing participants to two quotes, picked to be reflective of the inheritance tax debate.

One is by Thomas Piketty, and reads: *"Inheritance equality is nothing demagogical [...] We live in a society where 50% of the population inherits nothing, or almost nothing: the poorest half receives 5,000 or 10,000 euros, and often very late in life. This is the great limit of all social democracies up to now: in our system, the poorest 50% have nothing, and this is true for all age groups, and always has been. Never in history have the bottom 50% owned more than 10% of the capital."*

The other is by Nicolas Sarkozy, and reads: *"Family is by definition the place of transmission. When they've worked hard and paid their taxes, why should families be forbidden to pass on to their children the fruits of a whole generation's labour? What is more beautiful than wanting your children to start slightly better off than you started yourself?"*

4.1 Agreement with quotes and theme prevalence

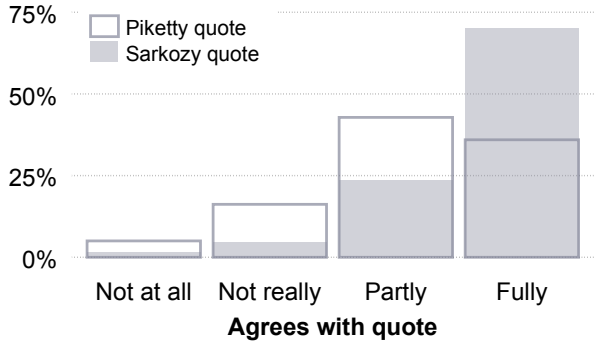
The participants are asked how much they agree with the quote on a 4-point Likert scale going from "Not at all" to "Fully". Figure 5 shows the distribution of agreement for both quotes. The

[17] For example, the Knowledge component consists only of questions about the inheritance tax, and not of knowldge questions specific to that tax.

Sarkozy quote is sizeably more popular: 71% of respondents fully agree with it, double the share of those who fully agree with the Piketty quote (36%).

This usefully completes the evidence collected in the previous section: not only do respondents, when prompted to think about the inheritance tax, spontaneously mention words that echo the Sarkozy quote; when presented with Thomas Piketty's argument, they also agree with it less on average.

Figure 5: Agreement with treatment quotes



Notes: Those overlaid histograms display the distribution of agreement with the Piketty quote (hollow bars) and the Sarkozy quote (light grey bars). Each treated participant saw only one of the two quotes. The quote and the agreement question were shown on the same survey page.

Another way of checking the prevalence of each quote's themes is to check the words used by participants in their answer to the open-ended question — remember that the open-ended answers are given before participants are shown the treatment. I define a set of "Piketty words" and "Sarkozy words", and look for answers containing those words. The words I select to define both themes are in Table 1; "Piketty words" are about inequality and distributive concerns, while Sarkozy words are about the efforts and hard work put in by a family. As shown in the last column, 6.1% of answers contain Piketty words, and almost three times more contain Sarkozy words.

Table 1: Definition of 'Piketty words' and 'Sarkozy words'

	Keywords	**Share of answers**
Piketty words	*equality, *distribution, *distribute, *equity, wealthy, large wealth, middle class, modest, poor, capital, financial, social justice, social category	6.1%
Sarkozy words	work hard, whole life, build, set aside, fruits, transfer, labour, sacrifice, family	16.3%
Both		1.3%

Note that selecting answers based on words do not necessarily mean participants will share the quote's opinion, but rather its themes. For example, among answers containing "Piketty words", we find answers that approve of the tax on redistributive grounds, such as: "Allows money to be re-distributed and prevents huge estates being passed down from generation to generation"; but other that oppose it on the same grounds, for example "Still favours the wealthy who can hide their wealth in tax havens." Those answers are both selected because they share a concern of the tax' distributional effects. Most answers containing Sarkozy words oppose the tax, but

they vary in their level of anger. We have for example "Why take more money from people who have worked all their lives to leave something to their children or grandchildren?" Some answers contain both Piketty and Sarkozy words, such as "Fair enough when it comes to very large estates, but completely unfair when it affects a modest household.".

4.2 Average treatment effects

The effect of each quote on attitudes towards the inheritance tax are obtained from the following regression:

$$z_i = \alpha + \beta^P T_i^P + \beta^S T_i^S + \Gamma W_i + \epsilon_i \tag{3}$$

where z_i is the participant's support index defined in Section 3.1, T_i^P (resp. T_i^S) is a variable equal to one if she was exposed to the Piketty (resp. Sarkozy) quote, zero otherwise, W_i is a vector of baseline controls, and Γ is a vector of coefficients. The two coefficients of interest are β^P and β^S, which capture the effect of each treatment on support for the inheritance tax.

The baseline estimates for treatment effects are displayed in Figure 6. Reading the Piketty quote increases the support index by .196 standard deviations. Figure A16 Panel A compares the distribution of support in the control and treatment groups and shows that some of that effect is a "deradicalising" one, with a decrease in extreme negative opinion and an increase in more mildly negative opinions; but that there is aso an increase in somewhat positive opinions. The Sarkozy quote on the other hand does not have a significant effect on support for the inheritance tax; if anything, contrary to expectations, the point estimate is positive.

Before trying to interpret this unexpected sign of the treatment effect, let us look at effects on other outcome variables, also depicted in Figure 6. The Piketty quote has increased support for the capital income tax, and has increased the perceived fairness of taxing wealthy parents who have themselves inherited. There are positive although not strongly significant effects on support for the labour income tax ($p = .108$), and the perceived fairness of taxing wealthy parents who have worked hard ($p = .185$). Those effects draw a coherent picture: reading the Piketty quote has increased support for progressive taxation, in particular when it targets wealthy individuals who have themselves inherited. The fact that the VAT and fuel tax are unaffected suggest that participants have read and understood the quote well, and that they wish, as a result, for a more progressive tax system.

The Sarkozy quote's effects are less straightforward to interpret. Reading the quote significantly increases the perceived fairness of taxing wealthy parents who have themselves inherited, by the same magnitude as the Piketty quote. It also increases support for the capital income tax, again by the same magnitude as the Piketty quote. There is some evidence of a positive effect on the labour income tax, and on the VAT. In a nutshell, the effects look somewhat comparable to those of the Piketty quote, even though we expected to find the opposite.

I formulate a few hypotheses that could explain this pattern. First, we have seen in the previous sections that support for the inheritance tax in the control group is strongly skewed towards the negative. For all variables measuring support, the mode is the most negative answer; and 30% of respondents in the control group have picked the lowest value on all the outcome questions. That implies that some of the non-negative effect could come from a binding lower bound on support.

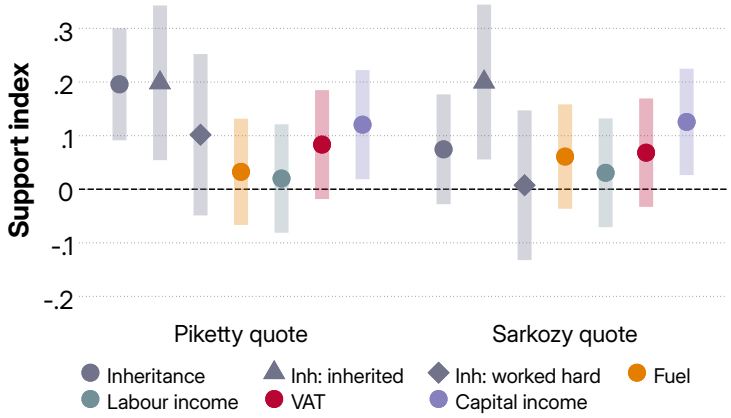
Second, as shown in Figure 5, 71% of participants state that they fully agree with the Sarkozy quote. That may imply that the quote has already saturated the debate about the inheritance tax, and that it has no effect because it already aligns with respondents' narratives.

Third, some participants may recognise the Sarkozy quote as an argument that they disagree with, or something they have heard from public figures that they disagree with. In this case, the argument could lead to exasperation and backfire. Such a mechanisms echoes that of "resistance" studied by the psychology literature, namely by Fatemi, Hasseldine and Hite (2008).

Fourth, the quote mentions hard working parents, which could increase the salience of effort for participants, and make them more supportive of taxes on "low-effort" wealth and income, such as inherited wealth or capital income.

Section 4.3 below explores those hypotheses by investigating heterogeneous treatment effects.

Figure 6: Treatment effects on the inheritance tax and other outcome variables



Notes: The Figure shows the β coefficients capturing treatment effects on support for the inheritance tax and on the other outcome variables presented in Section 1.1. Baseline controls are included. 95% confidence intervals are displayed.

Robustness. Figure A17 Panel A computes treatment effects on an unrestricted and a more strictly restricted samples: in the former, I keep all speeders; and in the latter, only participants who passed the attention check. Treatment effects are robust to those alternative samples. Point estimates are lower than the baseline in the unrestricted sample, and higher in the strictly restricted sample. Those results are consistent with speeders being inattentive respondents, on which treatment effects are smaller; and suggests that the somewhat positive effect of the Sarkozy quote is not noise from misunderstanding the quote or being inattentive.

Lastly, Table A7 shows the quotes' effect on each of the five variables that make up the support index (Support, Fairness, Matrix Fairness, Preferred level, Matrix Preferred Level); effects are shown on the average value of the variable, and on a dummy taking value 0 if the participant has chosen the most negative answer, 1 otherwise. The Piketty quote has a positive and significant effect on each dimension of support; the treatment effect is particularly large on the share of respondents who don't want the tax to be repealed.

Comparison with the literature. Treatment effects can be difficult to put in perspective in the demand for redistribution literature, namely because survey experiments often use different outcome variables. To address that gap, I replicate the specification of a few similar papers with

this project's data. I use the authors' preferred outcome variable (e.g. a dummy equal to 1 if the individual does not oppose the inheritance tax, in the case of Bastani and Waldenström (2021)) and the same set of controls. Figure A19 displays the results of this exercise, and shows that this experiment's effect sizes are not out of line with the literature; the effect of the Piketty quote is similar to the redistribution video's in Stantcheva (2021) when the outcome variable is a standardised support index. As shown in Figure A17 Panel C and D, effect sizes and significance depend on the outcome variable chosen. Alesina, Stantcheva and Teso (2018) for example use a dummy equal to 1 if the respondent supports the tax partly or completely, which does not yield significant treatment effects with this project's data — reflecting the fact that the Piketty quote has a "deradicalising" effect, but does not significantly increase the share of participants who actively support the tax.

4.3 Heterogeneous treatment effects

This Section investigates heterogeneous treatment effects to shed light on the persuasion pattern of both arguments.

By political leaning. I first explore effects by political affiliation, which in the existing literature tends to be a source of stark treatment heterogeneity. Figure 7 shows treatment effect interacted with political affiliation (split between left-, centre, and right-wing).

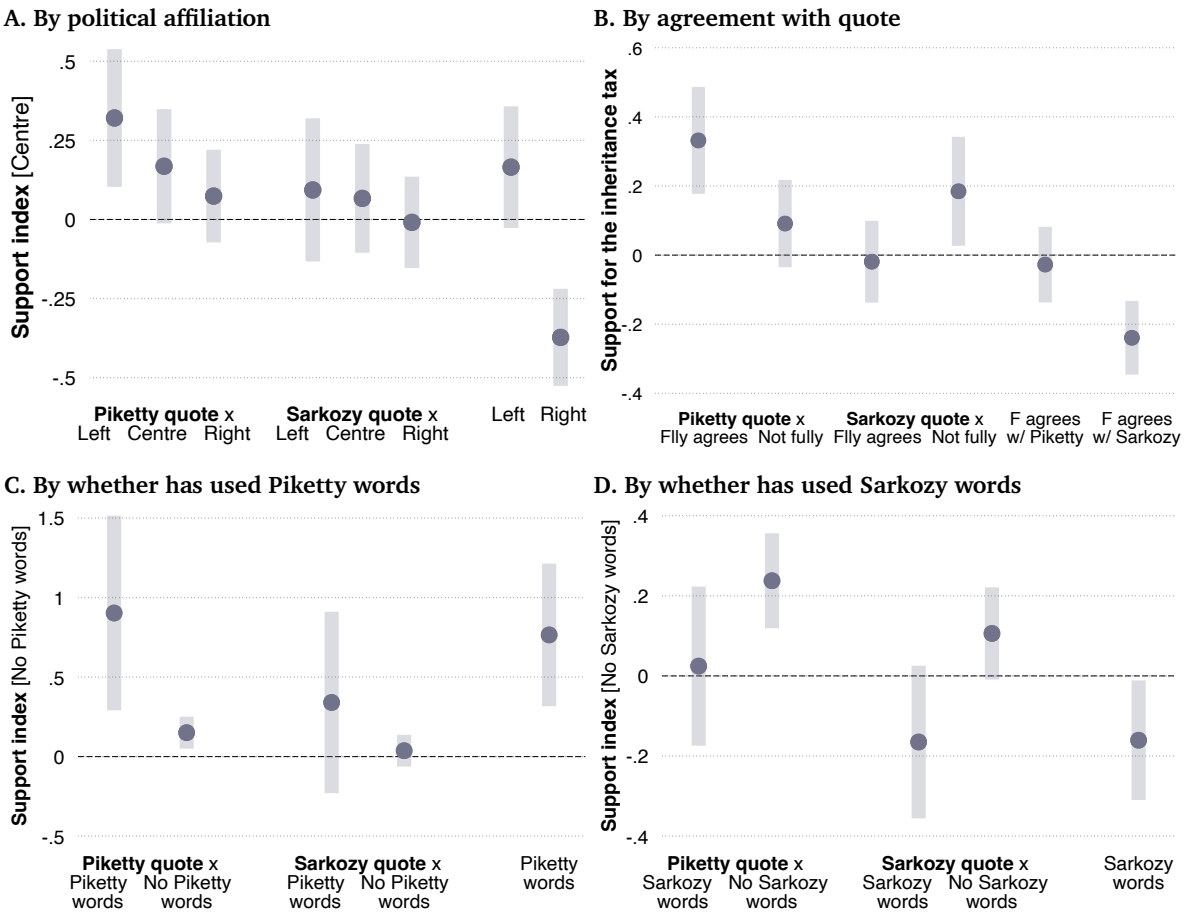
I find that the positive effect of the Piketty quote is driven by left-wing and centrist participants. The small positive effect of the Sarkozy quote also seems to come from left-wing and centrist participants. Figure A20 in Appendix shows similar results when participants are sorted based on their voting behaviour in the 2022 presidential election rather than their self-declared political affiliation. Those results could be indicative of partisan reasoning: participants are more likely to react in the expected way to a quote that correspond their political leaning.

By words used. We can round up this analysis of persuasion patterns by looking at the interaction between the treatments and words used by participants in their answers to the open-ended question. This analysis will allow to determine whether participants whose ex ante thoughts on the topic of the inheritance tax match one or the other argument are more or less likely to be convinced by it. The sets of Piketty and Sarkozy words are defined in Table 1. As previously stated, using Piketty or Sarkozy words does not mean that the answer echoes the quote's point of view, but only that it contains similar words, and therefore refers to similar themes.

Figure 7 shows the results in two separate regressions. Panel C shows heterogeneous effect for Piketty word users and non-users; a first thing to note is how much higher average support is among those who used Piketty words (the coefficient size is comparable to the "Taxes enhance fairness" dummy in the main regression, see Figure 3). The estimates in Panel A are somewhat imprecise, as only 6% of respondents are Piketty word users; but those participants exhibit a very large treatment effect, about 5 times as large as the average treatment effect on the whole sample. The effects of the Sarkozy quote are again not significantly different from zero, but the effect's point estimate for Piketty word users is large, suggesting a positive (though imprecisely estimated) treatment effect. The pattern looks similar to heterogeneity by political affiliation in Panel A: a weakly positive effect that is larger on those ideologically further away from the Sarkozy quote's point of view.

Finally, Panel D explores heterogeneity by Sarkozy word usage. The Piketty quote has no significant treatment effect on Sarkozy word users, and the point estimate is very close to zero:

Figure 7: Heterogeneous treatment effects on support for the inheritance tax



Notes: This graph shows the treatment effects of the two quotes interacted with political affiliation. Coefficients should be interpreted as follows: Piketty quote x left captures the difference in support between left-wing individuals in the control group and left-wing individuals in the Piketty treatment group. The "Left" and "Right" coefficients captures the average effect of being left-wing or right-wing on support. The reference category is control centrist individuals. Baseline controls are included, and 95% confidence intervals are displayed.

people for whom the "hard work" narrative is very salient are insensitive to Thomas Piketty's argument. Those who don't use Sarkozy words exhibit a positive and significant treatment effect. The Sarkozy quote however, for the first time in this experimental section, appears to have a negative (although significant only at the 10% level) treatment effect on Sarkozy word users. This subgroup of participants is the only one that displays the expected treatment effect. Lastly, the treatment effect is positive on Sarkozy word non-users ($p = .085$).

The three variables studied are source of stark treatment heterogeneity; and the evidence seems to suggest that when it comes to the inheritance tax, arguments can only have their desired effect on those predisposed to agree with them. On those who do not agree, those same arguments can have a smaller effect at best, and at worst, push their audience in the direction opposite to what they intended. Going back to the hypotheses formulated in Section 4.2, there is evidence of saturation that is difficult to disentangle from lower bound effects: on the one hand, the treatment effect on those who fully agree with the Sarkozy quote is zero, and those who (are predicted to) fully agree with the quote without having seen the treatment show significantly lower support. This suggests that the Sarkozy quote has had its effects before it's shown to the

participants. On the other hand, users of Sarkozy words are the only subgroup on whom the treatment effect is negative, suggesting reinforcement rather than saturation.

The picture is clearer on the third and fourth hypotheses: the whole positive treatment effect of the Sarkozy quote is driven by those who are not right-wing, do not agree with the quote, and do not use the same words. This supports the claim that the positive treatment effects come from backfiring. It is more doubtful that the mechanism is that hard work is made more salient, since that mechanism should not vary strongly by agreement with the quote, and cannot explain the negative treatment effect on users of Sarkozy words—the subgroup for whom hard work is arguably most salient.

By agreement with the quote. To investigate this channel more precisely, it is useful to interact treatment effects with how much participants agree with the quote. Unfortunately, the agreement variable is only available for participants in a given treatment group; to be able to interact the treatment with agreement, we need that variable for all observations. I define agreement as a dummy equal to 1 if the participant Fully agrees with their quote, and calibrate a LASSO model on the treatment group. I then use that model to predict agreement for the whole sample, and use the prediction as the interaction variable.

The results are depicted in Figure 7 Panel B. Because the prediction is less precise than the true value of the variable, the interaction patterns shown are a lower bound on the true underlying effects' heterogeneity. The effects are asymmetrical and tell an interesting story: people who fully agree with the Piketty quote display a stronger treatment effect, consistent with partisan reasoning. The effect is also positive (although significant only at the 10% level) on participants who don't fully agree. The Sarkozy quote on the other hand has no effect on those who fully agree with it, but a clear, positive effect on those who don't, comparable in size to the effect of the Piketty quote. The Sarkozy quote gives rise to a form of "negative partisan reasoning"; it has no effect on its proponents, and a backfiring effect on those it does not fully convinces. Note that participants who fully agree with the Sarkozy quote are also much more opposed to the tax.

4.4 Mechanisms: treatment effects on perceptions

Because of the survey design described in Section 1.1, respondents who are in a treatment group *and* see the tax section first are exposed to treatment before they fill in the perceptions section. Comparing those respondents to others allows to investigate treatment effects on the mediating variables measured in the perceptions section. The causal effect of each treatment on outcome variable y for participant i is captured by coefficients ζ^P, ζ^S in the following equation:

$$y_i = \alpha + \zeta^P(T_i^P \times D_i) + \zeta^S(T_i^S \times D_i) + \beta^P T_i^P + \beta^S T_i^S + \theta D_i + \gamma W_i + \epsilon_i \tag{4}$$

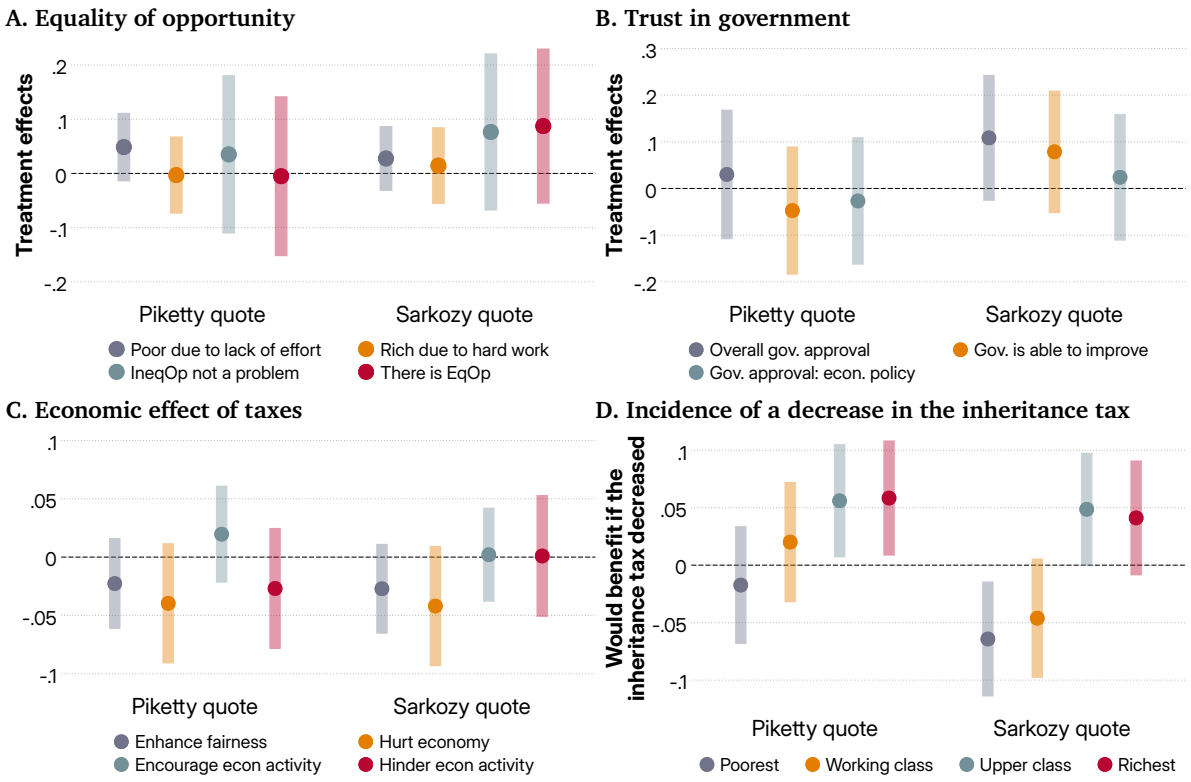
where D_i is equal to 1 if participant i is in the "Tax first" group, zero otherwise; T_i^P (resp. T_i^S) is equal to one if the participant is treated with the Piketty (resp. Sarkozy) quote, zero otherwise.

Figure 8 Panels A studies treatment effects on beliefs about equality of opportunity:

and B focus on two mechanisms commonly studied in the literature about demand for redistribution: Equality of opportunity and Trust in government.

Four variables relate to Equality of opportunity, all signed so that larger values imply that inequality of opportunity is less of a concern: a dummy equal to one if the participant answered that poverty could be mainly attributed to a "Lack of effort" rather than "Circumstances beyond

Figure 8: Treatment effects on mediating variables



Notes: This figure shows treatment effects on mediating variables.

their control"[18]: a dummy equal to one if they answered that someone being rich was due mainly to "Having worked harder than others" rather than "Having more privileges than others"[19]; a standardised version of the answer to "If children from poor and rich families don't have the same opportunities, is that:", with answers going from "A very serious problem" to "Not a problem" on a 5-point Likert scale; and lastly, a standardised version of the answer to "What is your opinion about the following statement? In France currently, everybody has a chance to make it and reach the top of the social ladder", with answers going from "Don't agree at all" to "Fully agree" on a 5-point Likert scale.

It does not appear that changes in views on equality of opportunity drive the treatment effects. No significant effect is visible on any of the variables; we could have expected the Piketty quote in particular to shift views, for example to push participants to be less likely to believe that "everybody has a chance to make it". If anything, and counter-inutitively, it looks as if slightly more respondents believe that a main reason that people are poor is because of a lack of effort.

Turning to trust in government, participants are asked two main questions: the first one asks participants how often they agree with the government's decisions in the cultural, economic, international relations, health, and social policy domains, on a Never to Always 5-point Likert scale. Those measures are standardised, and aggregated into an index, standardised in turn,

[18]The question offered three options in total: "Lack of effort", "Circumstances beyond one's control", and "Other", which then prompted the participant to type an open-ended answer. That third option is excluded in this graph, and the dummy takes a missing value if the participant selected "Other".

[19]Again, a third "Other" option was included among the answers but excluded from the analysis here.

which I label "Overall gov approval". The second question asks whether the government, if that was its intention, would have the ability and tools to establish equality of opportunity; the participants' answer, on a "Absolutely not" to "Absolutely" 4-point Likert scale, is similarly standardised.

Here again, no decisive motif emerges. The channel studied in the literature is that trust in government is positively associated with demand for redistribution (Kuziemko et al. 2015); here the Piketty quote, which increases support for taxation, does not appear to increase support for governmental action. The Sarkozy quote appears to increase approval of governmental decisions slightly, although mostly through the international policy channel, which is of limited relevance to the topic of demand for redistribution.

Panel C and D show treatment effects on two variables that always appear after treatment for all treated respondents (appearing in the Tax section and the Feedback section respectively, see Figure 1); hence treatment effects on variable y_i for participant i are measured like in equation 3 by coefficients β^P, β^S:

$$y_i = \alpha + \beta^P T_i^P + \beta^S T_i^S + \gamma W_i + \epsilon_i \tag{5}$$

where T_i^P (resp. T_i^S) is equal to one if the participant is treated with the Piketty (resp. Sarkozy) quote, zero otherwise, and W_i is a vector of controls.

Panel C is based on a question asking participants to evaluate the effect a decrease in the inheritance would have on five social categories: the poorest, lower class, middle class, upper class, and the wealthiest. The question asks, in a matrix format, whether each category would lose, not be affected, or gain from a lower inheritance tax.

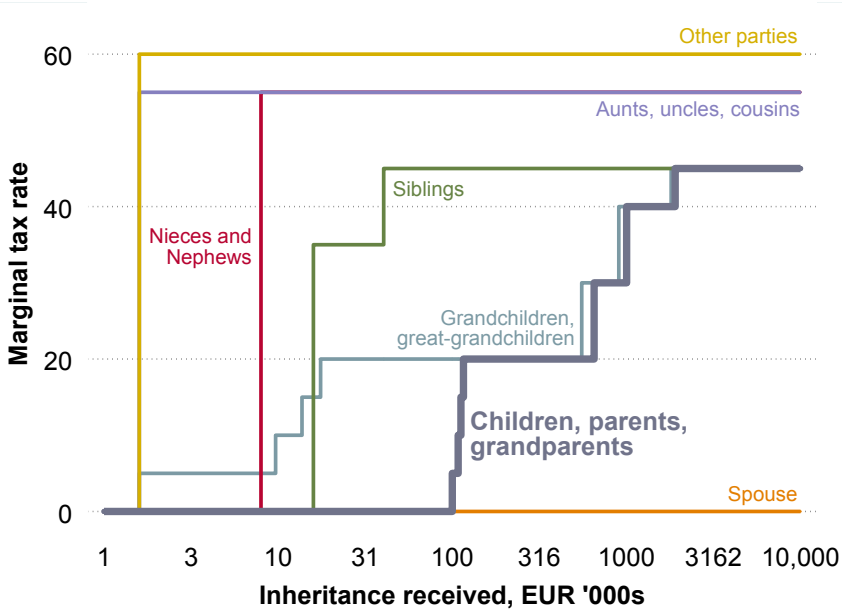
This time, treatment effects appear. Interestingly, the effects of the two quotes are not dissimilar: both push respondents to say that the two wealthiest categories would gain from a lower inheritance tax; the effect on the poorest categories is not significant for the Piketty quote, whereas the Sarkozy quote decreases the share of respondents believing in "trickle down effects", that is, that the poorer categories would benefit from a lower inheritance tax.

Conclusion

This project sheds a new light on the roots of the puzzlingly low support for the inheritance tax. The tax is indeed unpopular, and a key reason is that it is perceived as a tax on hard working individuals and not on the wealthy. Self-interest and knowledge about the tax explain little variation in support. Instead, beliefs about equity and efficiency, and in particular the perceived *effect* of taxes on equity and efficiency, play a larger role. These preferences are not immutable however: a quote telling participants about the inequality of the inherited wealth distribution significantly increases support, even among participants who don't entirely agree with this narrative; while a quote echoing the seemingly dominating narrative (the inheritance tax is an unfair tax on a lifetime of hard work) does not push its supporters to support the tax less, and instead backfires on the (minority) of individuals who do not fully agree with it. Those asymmetrical effects suggest that dominating narratives are not all-powerful, and that challenging those narratives can be more effective to shift opinions, even on a topic as unpopular and polarised as the inheritance tax.

A Extra figures and tables

Figure A1: Marginal tax rate vs. size of inheritance received, by beneficiary group, in France in 2022



Notes: This Figure shows how marginal tax rates on inheritance evolve with the size of the bequest received, depending on the relationship between the donor and the receiver.

Table A1: Regression of support for the inheritance tax on a dummy for failing the attention check

A. Full base sample

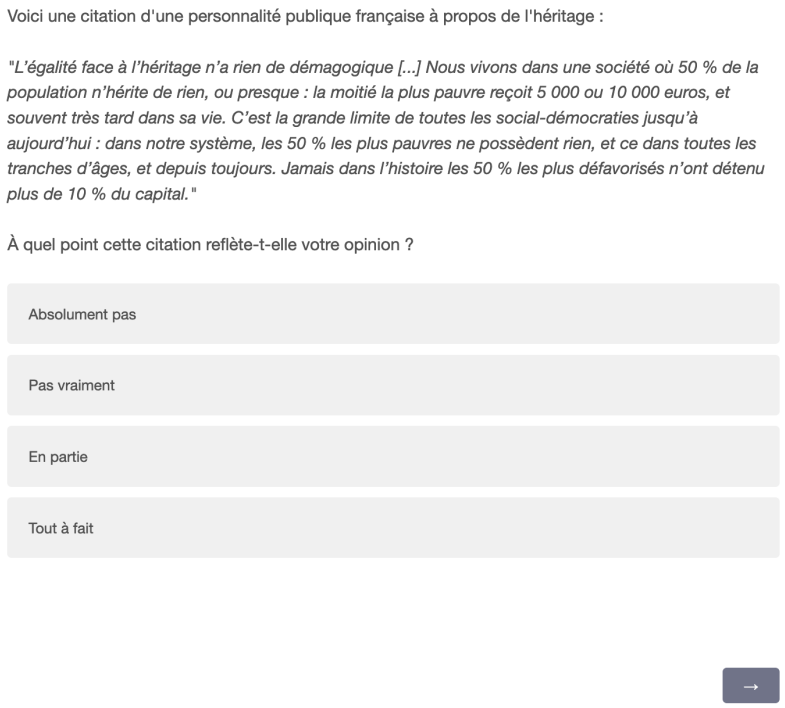
	All	Control group	Piketty group	Sarkozy group
Failed attention check	0.28***	0.45***	0.29***	0.11
	(0.04)	(0.07)	(0.08)	(0.08)
Observations	2383	792	787	804
Baseline controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

B. Excluding speeders

	All	Control group	Piketty group	Sarkozy group
Failed attention check	0.01	0.10	0.00	-0.05
	(0.04)	(0.08)	(0.08)	(0.08)
Observations	2125	702	697	726
Baseline controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Panel A includes the full base sample, i.e. all individuals who consented to participating in the survey, and were not screened out because the belonged to a quota that was full. Panel B only includes individuals who either passed the attention check, or failed but were not flagged as speeders. Speeders are individuals who spent less time answering the full survey than the 5th percentile among those who passed the attention check, computed within their treatment group. The main outcome variable, i.e. the index of support for the inheritance tax, is regressed on a dummy for failing the attention check; Panel B shows that once speeders are excluded, failing the attention check is no longer associated with significantly higher support for the tax, in the full sample or in any treatment group. The number of observations is smaller than indicated in the text because baseline controls are included (demographics, income, wealth, political affiliation) and some of those controls are missing for a couple of respondents.

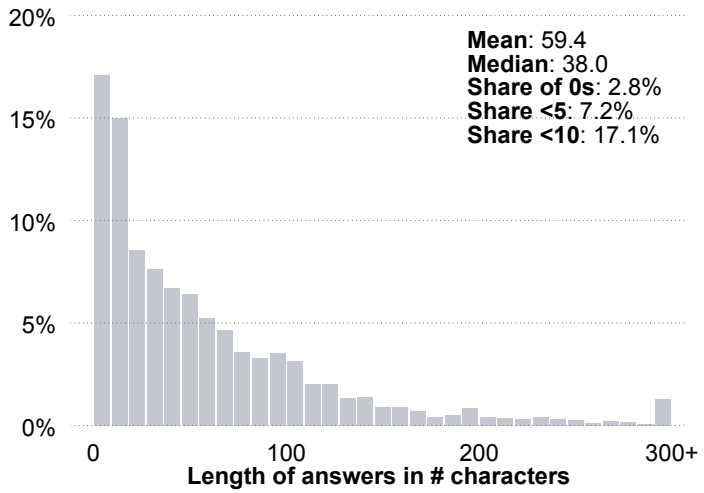
Figure A2: Appearance of treatment quote in the survey (Thomas Piketty's quote)



Notes: This figure is a screenshot taken from the survey, showing how treated participants in the Piketty group were shown the treatment quote. The quote was the only thing displayed on that page, and after replying, participants could click on the arrow in the lower right corner to move to the next page. They were not forced to spend a minimum amount of time on this page, nor were they forced to answer the question; if they didn't, they received a reminder upon clicking the arrow, but could ignore that warning and move to the next section.

Back to Section 1.2

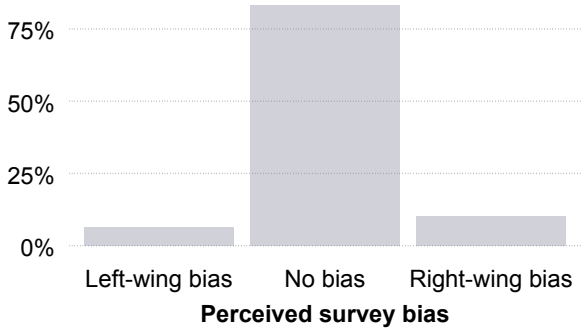
Figure A3: Distribution of length of answers to the open-ended question



Notes: This figure shows the distribution of the length (in characters, spaces excluded) of answers given to the open-ended question, which was phrased as follows "The inheritance tax, also called 'succession duty' is a tax collected by the state on the transfer of wealth from a deceased person to their heirs. Can you describe in a few sentences what this tax brings to your mind?".

Back to Section 1.3.2

Figure A4: Perceived survey bias



Notes: This figure shows the distribution of answers to the question "Did you think that this survey was politically biased?", asked at the end of the questionnaire, in the Feedback section.

Back to Section 1.3.2

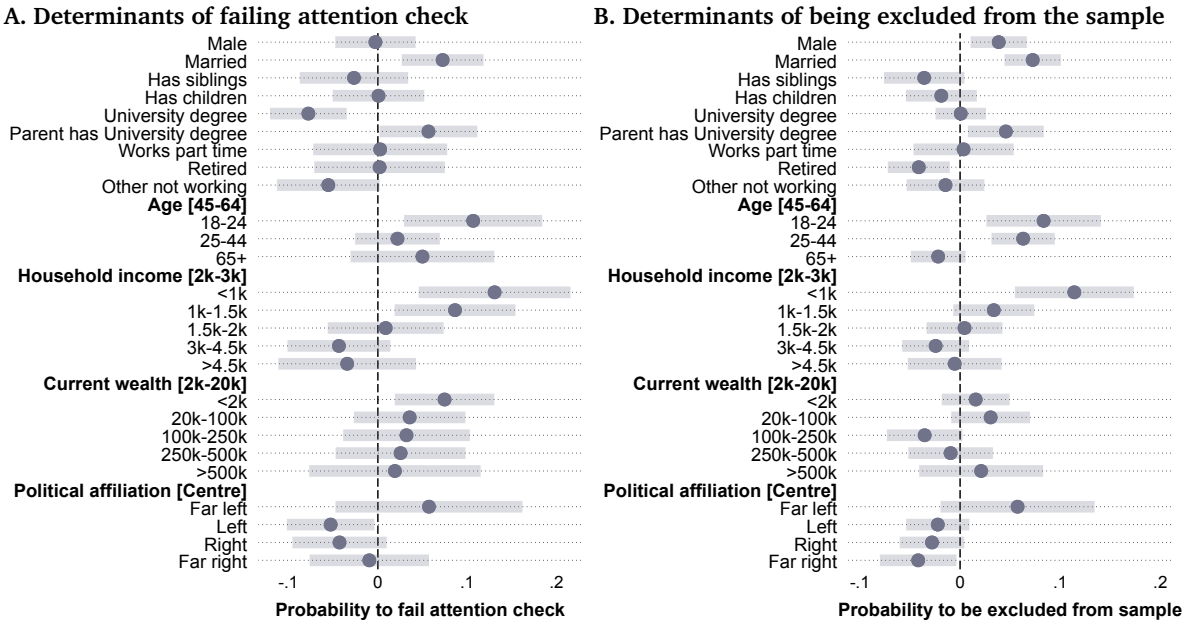
Table A2: Sample representativity

	Sample	French pop
Male	0.47	0.49
Married	0.45	0.54
18-34 years old	0.27	0.28
35-64 years old	0.59	0.54
65+ years old	0.12	0.17
Less than high school	0.06	0.18
High school	0.44	0.41
Short uni	0.36	0.14
Long uni	0.14	0.26
<1500€	0.27	0.14
1500-2500€	0.29	0.30
2500-3500€	0.21	0.29
3500€+	0.23	0.27
Voted for Macron	0.34	0.39
Voted for Le Pen	0.33	0.27
Didn't vote	0.33	0.34
N(obs)	2,295	

Notes: This table compares the mean value of a few key demographics in the main sample (left-hand side column) and the French population (right-hand side).

Back to Section 1.3.3

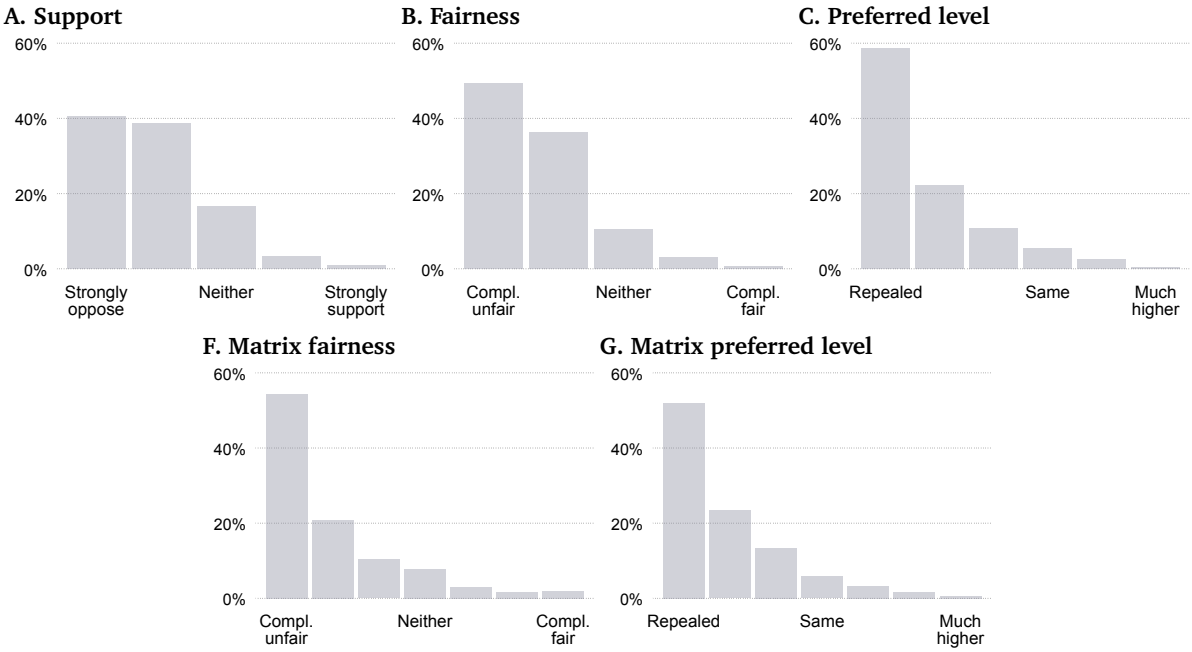
Figure A5: Determinants of failing the attention check and being excluded from the sample



Notes: This figure shows the results from an OLS regression of a dummy for failing the attention check (Panel A) or being excluded from the sample (Panel B). Individuals are excluded from the sample if they failed the attention check **and** were flagged as speeders (see Section 1.3.1). 95% confidence intervals are displayed.

Back to Section 1.3.1

Figure A6: Distribution of answers to the main support questions



Notes: Distribution of answers to the five main support questions in the control group (N = 756). The Support and Fairness questions are answered on a 1 to 5 Likert scale; the Preferred level question on a 1 to 6 Likert scale; and the two Matrix questions on a 1 to 7 Likert scale.

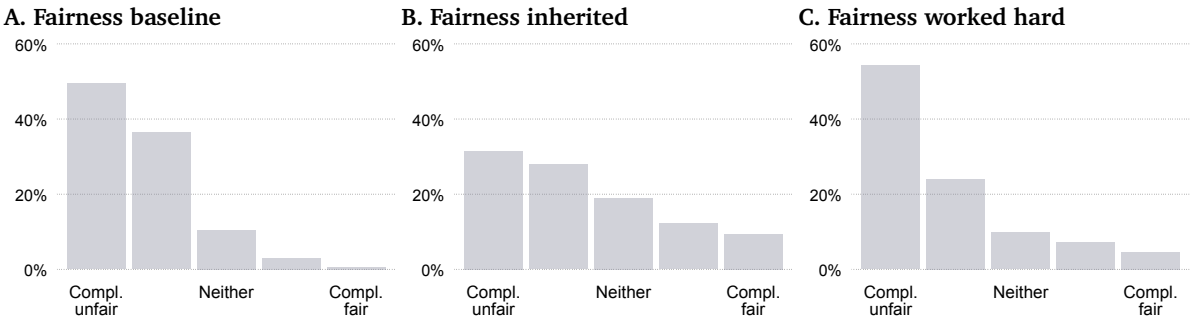
Table A3: Covariate balance by treatment group

	Control mean	Piketty mean	Sarkozy mean	Control-Piketty diff p-val	Control-Sarkozy diff p-val
Male	0.47	0.48	0.45	0.54	0.64
Less than 25 yo	0.10	0.12	0.10	0.23	0.97
University	0.46	0.52	0.53	0.01	0.01
Part time	0.08	0.08	0.09	0.80	0.38
Retired	0.18	0.17	0.21	0.42	0.16
Not working	0.19	0.20	0.19	0.68	0.92
<1k	0.10	0.10	0.09	0.55	0.52
1k-1.5k	0.18	0.17	0.17	0.42	0.48
1.5k-2k	0.17	0.17	0.17	0.97	0.93
2k-3k	0.21	0.22	0.23	0.58	0.35
3k-4.5k	0.24	0.23	0.23	0.75	0.80
>4.5k	0.10	0.10	0.11	0.88	0.51
<2k	0.33	0.32	0.32	0.57	0.45
2k-20k	0.22	0.21	0.23	0.64	0.83
20k-100k	0.16	0.16	0.17	0.97	0.80
100k-250k	0.12	0.14	0.10	0.46	0.21
250k-500k	0.10	0.11	0.13	0.59	0.06
>500k	0.05	0.05	0.05	0.80	0.81
Married	0.44	0.45	0.44	0.69	0.76
Has siblings	0.86	0.90	0.87	0.05	0.62
Has children	0.72	0.69	0.71	0.13	0.46
Parent has uni degree	0.15	0.17	0.16	0.24	0.41
Far left	0.04	0.04	0.03	0.73	0.59
Left	0.28	0.31	0.27	0.22	0.62
Centre	0.32	0.31	0.36	0.84	0.08
Right	0.24	0.21	0.22	0.11	0.24
Far right	0.12	0.13	0.12	0.70	0.98
N(obs)	736	728	747		

Notes: The three first columns show the average value of each variable in the control group, the Piketty treatment group, and the Sarkozy treatment group. The last two columns show the p-value of the the test for equal means between the control group and the Piketty treatment group, and between the control group and the Sarkozy treatment group respectively. The sample is the main sample that excludes speeders, as described in Section 1.3.1.

Back to Section 1.3.3

Figure A7: Distribution of answers to additional fairness questions



Notes: Distribution of answers to the Fairness and the two alternative Fairness questions in the control group (N = 756). Questions are answered on a 1 to 5 Likert scale.

Back to Section 3.1

Table A4: Covariates balance by treatment group, unrestricted sample

	Control mean	Piketty mean	Sarkozy mean	Control-Piketty diff p-val	Control-Sarkozy diff p-val
Male	0.47	0.48	0.46	0.59	0.82
Less than 25 yo	0.11	0.13	0.11	0.13	0.77
University	0.46	0.52	0.53	0.01	0.01
Part time	0.08	0.08	0.09	0.84	0.53
Retired	0.16	0.15	0.20	0.43	0.08
Not working	0.19	0.21	0.19	0.37	0.78
<1k	0.11	0.12	0.10	0.42	0.51
1k-1.5k	0.19	0.16	0.17	0.20	0.43
1.5k-2k	0.17	0.17	0.17	0.85	0.76
2k-3k	0.21	0.22	0.23	0.57	0.20
3k-4.5k	0.24	0.23	0.22	0.85	0.41
>4.5k	0.09	0.10	0.11	0.61	0.15
<2k	0.35	0.33	0.33	0.42	0.35
2k-20k	0.22	0.21	0.22	0.60	0.89
20k-100k	0.16	0.17	0.18	0.91	0.54
100k-250k	0.12	0.13	0.09	0.45	0.09
250k-500k	0.10	0.10	0.13	0.62	0.02
>500k	0.05	0.06	0.05	0.47	0.90
Married	0.45	0.46	0.44	0.85	0.55
Has siblings	0.86	0.89	0.87	0.05	0.41
Has children	0.71	0.67	0.70	0.11	0.52
Parent has uni degree	0.16	0.18	0.17	0.26	0.57
Far left	0.04	0.05	0.04	0.28	0.82
Left	0.28	0.31	0.27	0.22	0.52
Centre	0.33	0.32	0.36	0.48	0.23
Right	0.23	0.20	0.22	0.21	0.53
Far right	0.12	0.12	0.11	0.83	0.83
N(obs)	848	835	838		

Notes: The three first columns show the average value of each variable in the control group, the Piketty treatment group, and the Sarkozy treatment group. The last two columns show the p-value of the the test for equal means between the control group and the Piketty treatment group, and between the control group and the Sarkozy treatment group respectively. The sample is the fully unrestricted sample.

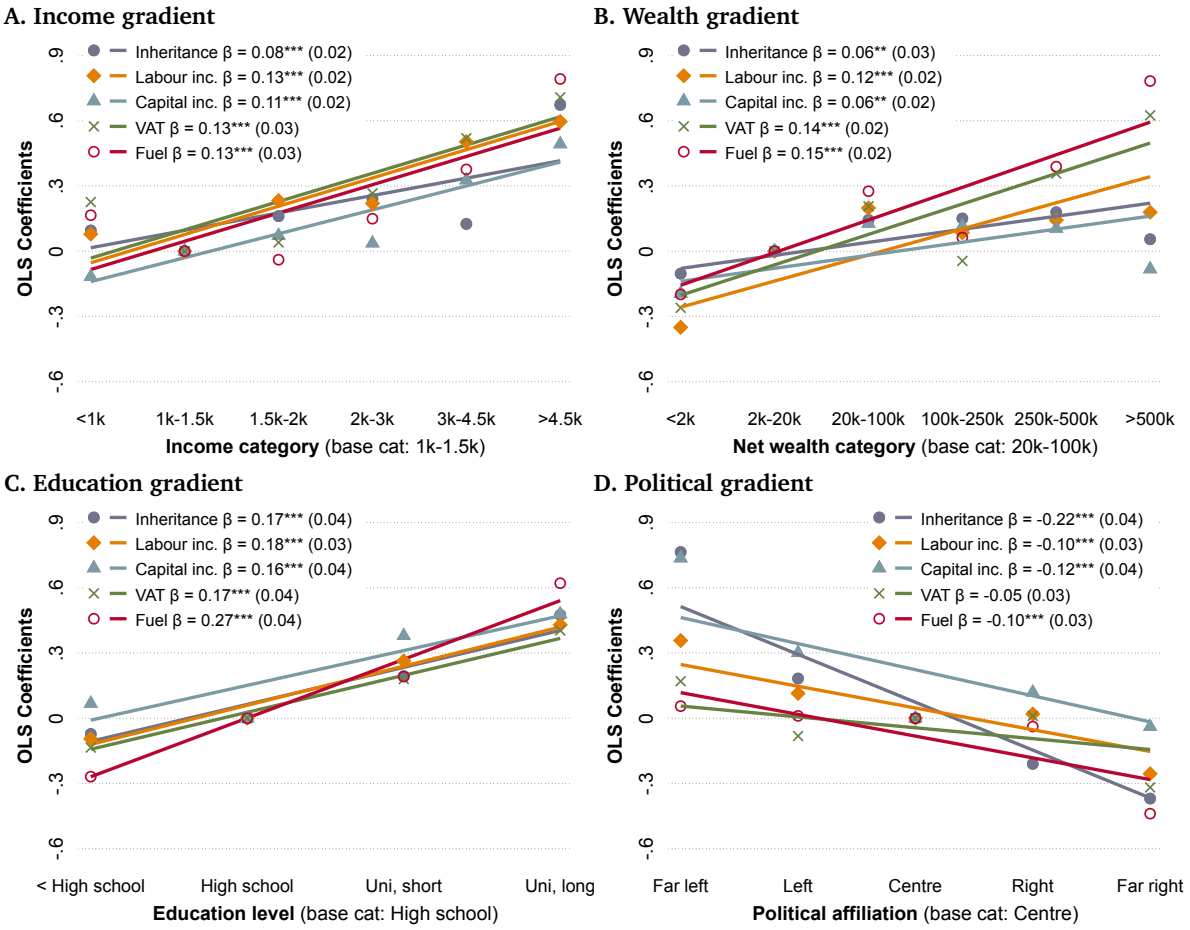
Back to Section 1.3.3

Table A5: Correlation between five main outcome variables

	Support	Fairness	Preferred level	Matrix fairness	Matrix level
Support	1.00	0.77	0.68	0.64	0.67
Fairness	0.77	1.00	0.66	0.62	0.63
Preferred level	0.68	0.66	1.00	0.75	0.78
Matrix fairness	0.64	0.62	0.75	1.00	0.83
Matrix level	0.67	0.63	0.78	0.83	1.00

Notes: This table displays the correlation matrix of the five variables measuring support for the inheritance tax in the control group. Those five variables are standardised, averaged together and standardised again to build the support index that constitutes the main outcome variable of interest throughout the analysis.

Figure A8: Income, wealth, education and political gradient of support for various taxes, without controls



Notes: Each graph displays the results of regressing the support index for five different taxes on income, wealth, education and political affiliation. The straight line and β coefficient displayed on the graph result from regressing support on each independent variable linearly; while the dots correspond to a regression on the independent variable in categories, labeled on the x-axis. All regressions include the independent variable mentioned in the panel's title as their only regressor.

Figure A9: Adjusted R^2 from regressing taxes' support index on socio-economic controls

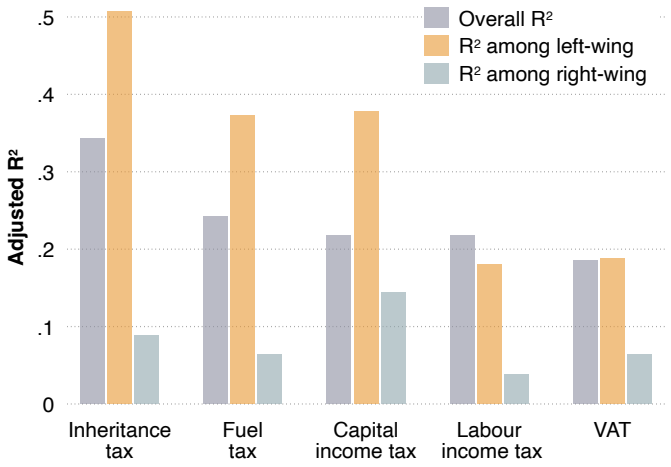
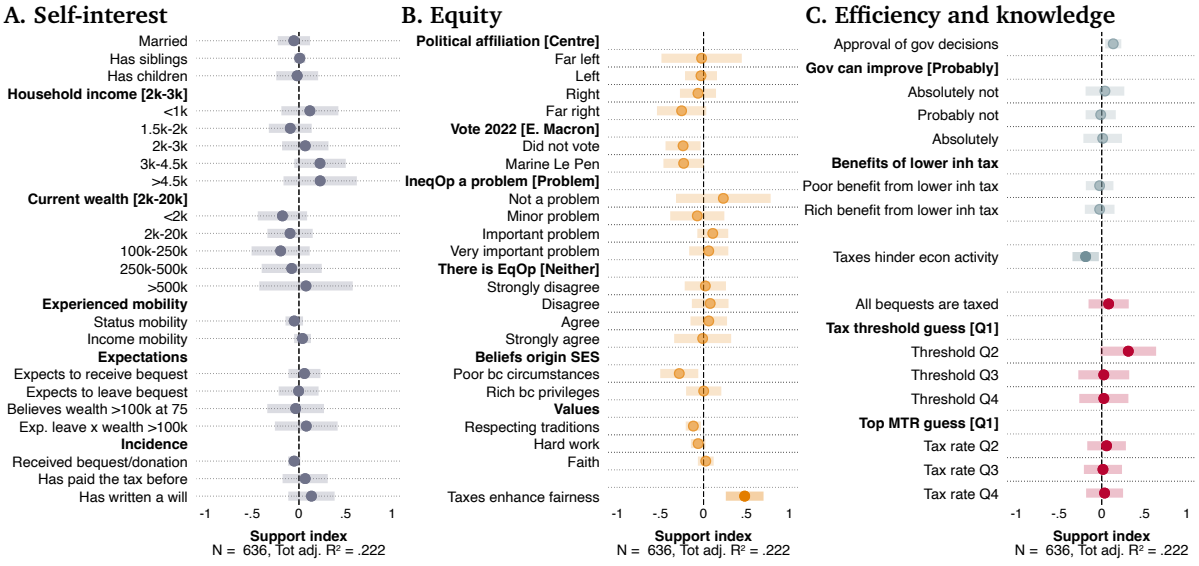


Table A6: Cross-explainability of support for taxes

	Total R2	R2 of other taxes	Share of other taxes in R2
Inheritance tax	0.30	0.19	0.63
Labour income tax	0.41	0.36	0.90
Capital income tax	0.35	0.26	0.76
VAT	0.46	0.42	0.92
Fuel tax	0.47	0.40	0.87

Notes: For each of the five taxes studied, this table shows how much of their support can be explained by support for other taxes. To illustrate this, each support index is regressed on the baseline set of covariates shown in Figure 3 as well as on support indices for the four other taxes. Column 1 shows the total adjusted R^2 from that regression. Column 2 shows the Shapley-Owen share of R^2 explained by support for the four other taxes. Column 3 shows the ratio of Column 2 on Column 1, that is, the share of total explained variance attributed to support for other taxes.

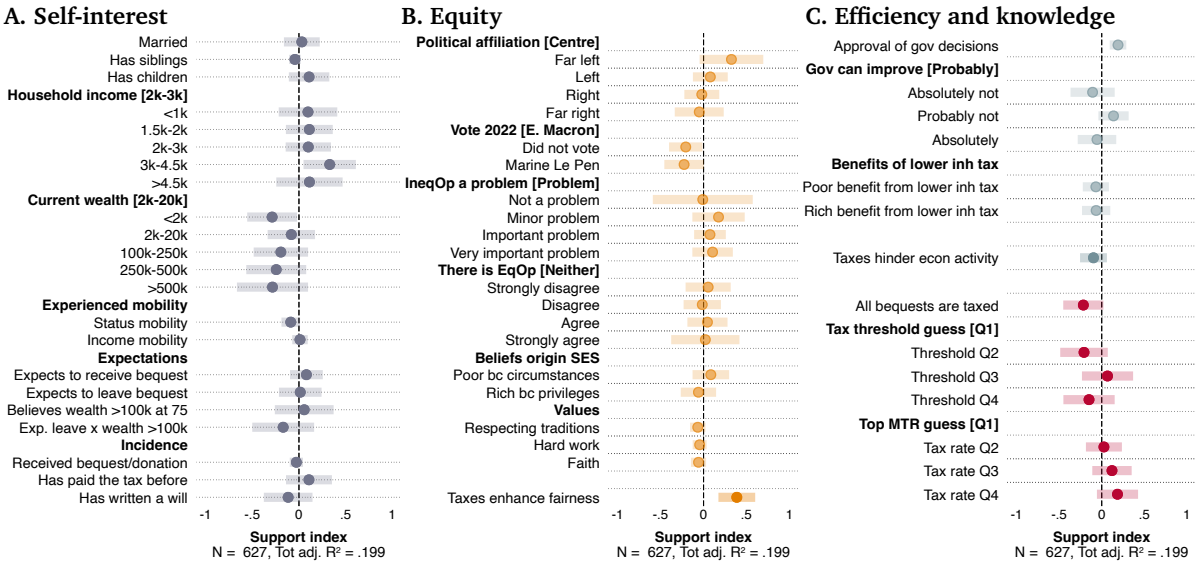
Figure A10: Regression of support for the fuel tax



Notes: The graph plots coefficients from an OLS regression of the support index for the fuel tax on the full set of controls. The three panels correspond to a single regression including all covariates at once. The regression also includes controls for gender, age, education, region of residence, and work status, not reported.

Back to Section 3.2

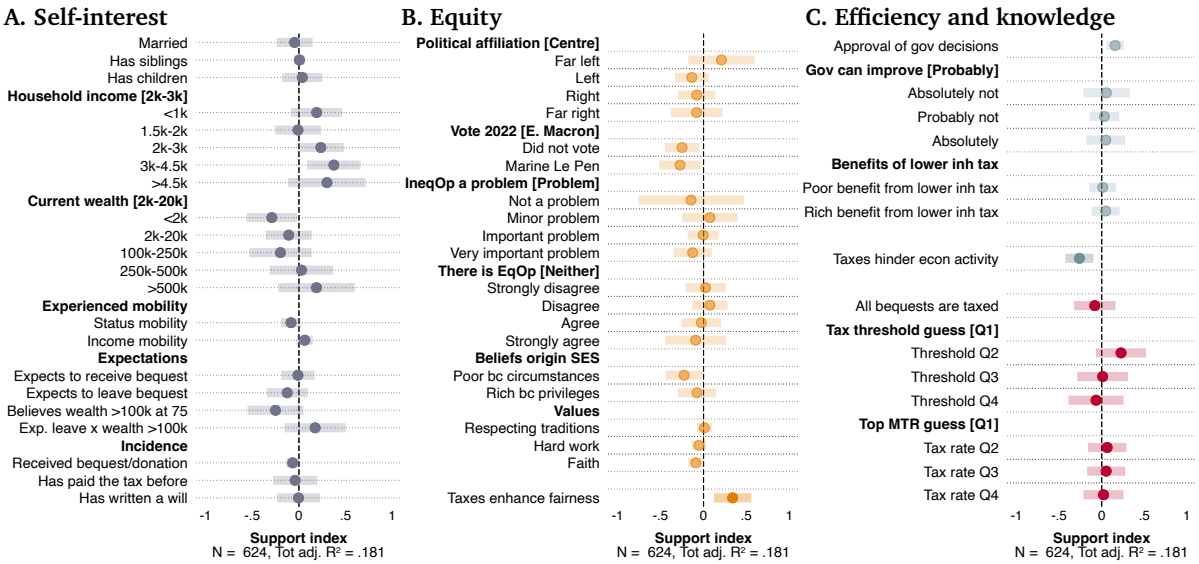
Figure A11: Regression of support for the labour income tax



Notes: The graph plots coefficients from an OLS regression of the support index for the labour income tax on the full set of controls. The three panels correspond to a single regression including all covariates at once. The regression also includes controls for gender, age, education, region of residence, and work status, not reported.

Back to Section **??**

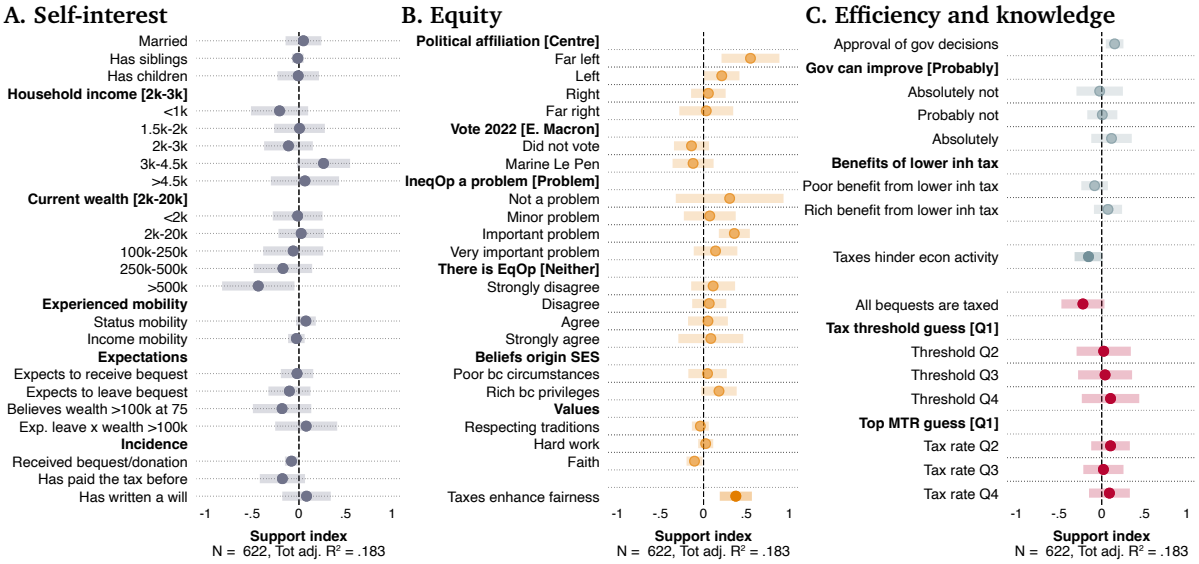
Figure A12: Regression of support for the VAT



Notes: The graph plots coefficients from an OLS regression of the support index for the VAT on the full set of controls. The three panels correspond to a single regression including all covariates at once. The regression also includes controls for gender, age, education, region of residence, and work status, not reported.

Back to Section **??**

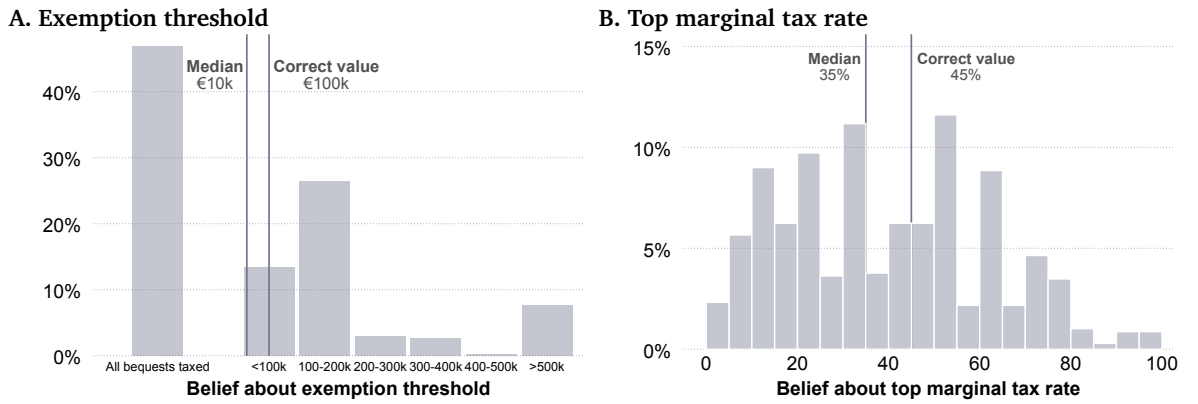
Figure A13: Regression of support for the capital income tax



Notes: The graph plots coefficients from an OLS regression of the support index for the capital income tax on the full set of controls. The three panels correspond to a single regression including all covariates at once. The regression also includes controls for gender, age, education, region of residence, and work status, not reported.

Back to Section 3.2

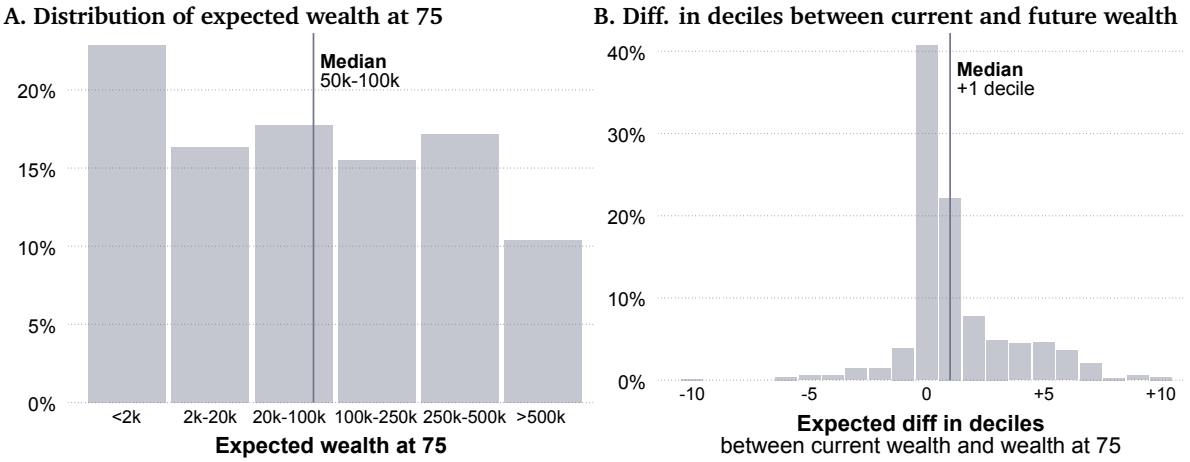
Figure A14: Knowledge of the inheritance tax



Notes: This Figure shows the distribution of answers to the knowledge questions in the control group.

Back to Section **??**

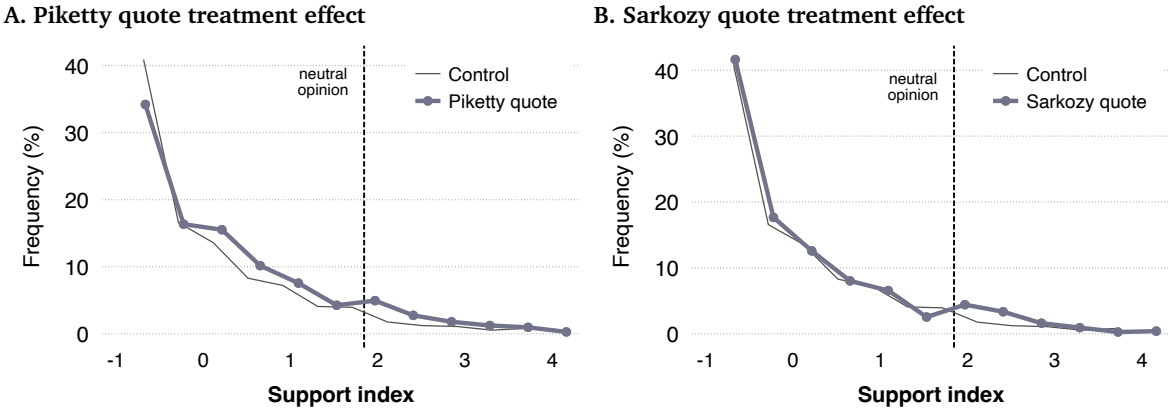
Figure A15: Expectations about wealth at 75



Notes: Those two histograms shows the distribution of answers to the questions "How much net wealth do you expect to have by the time you turn 75?" and "Do you expect to leave a substantial bequest to your children in the future? By substantial, we mean equal to at least 6 months of your salary, or if you don't currently earn a salary, to at least 6 months of your last salary." For the latter, answers were "Yes", "No", "I do not plan to have children", and "Other".

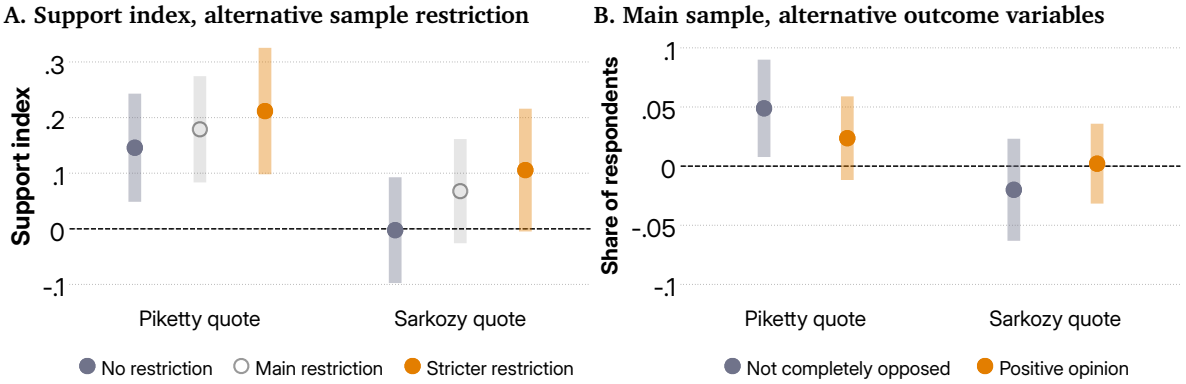
Back to Section **??**

Figure A16: Treatment effect of quotes on support index distribution



Notes: The figures compare the distribution of the support index in the control and treatment groups.

Figure A17: Treatment effect on support for the inheritance tax, alternative samples and outcome variables



Notes: This figure complements Figure **??** and shows the β coefficients capturing treatment effects specified in equation 3. 95% confidence intervals are displayed. In Panel A, speeders are not excluded ($N = 2,521$) in the blue series, and only participants who passed the attention check are included ($N = 1,548$) in the orange series; in Panel B, the outcome variable is a dummy taking value 0 if the participant gave the most negative answer to the 5 support questions, 1 otherwise for the blue series; or the outcome variable is a dummy taking value 0 is the participant gave a negative answer (1 to 3 out of 7) to the 5 support questions, 1 otherwise for the orange series.

Back to Section 4.2

Figure A18: Treatment effects by order of survey sections



Notes: This graph shows the treatment effects of the two quotes separately in the Perceptions first and in the Tax first groups — the former group answered all the perceptions question before being asked the open-ended question and seeing the treatment if treated; the latter saw the open-ended question and treatment right after the demographics section. Baseline controls are included, and 95% confidence intervals are displayed.

Back to Section **??**

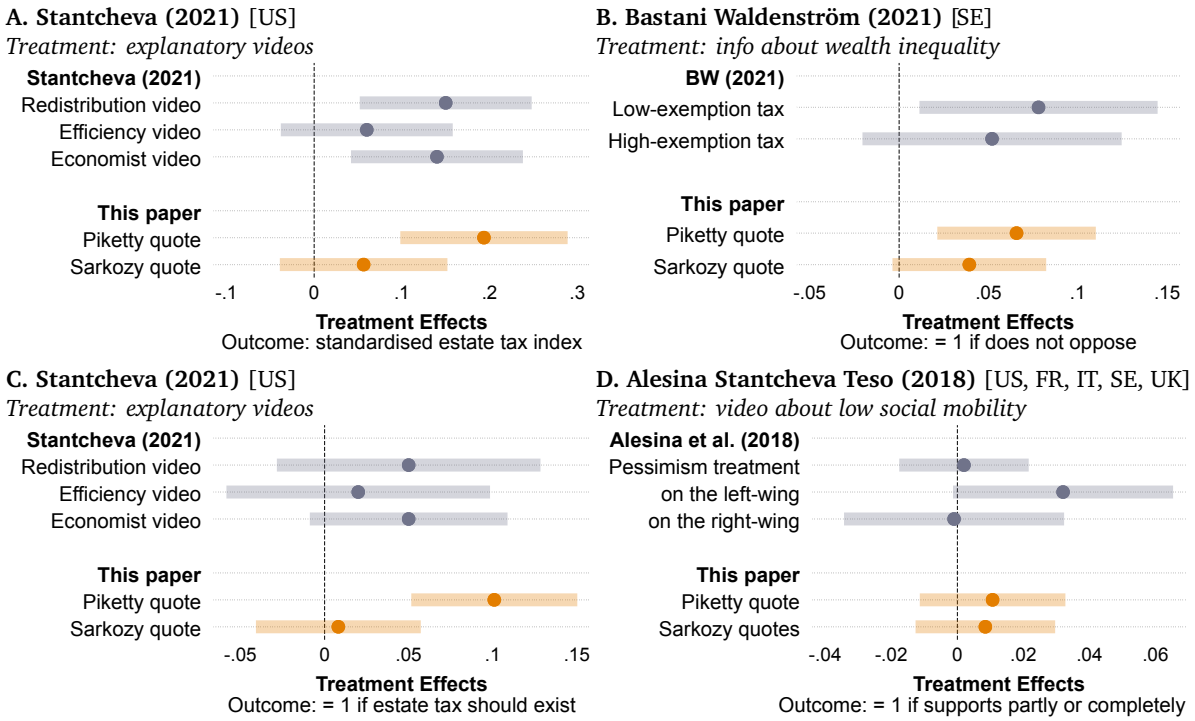
Table A7: Treatment effects, by individual outcome variable

	Average outcome variable				Not most negative answer			
	Treatment effect	p-val	Mean in C group	Eff size in %	Treatment effect	p-val	Mean in C group	Eff size in %
Piketty quote								
Support	0.13	0.005	1.85	8.4	0.05	0.046	0.59	8.4
Fairness	0.11	0.009	1.69	13.3	0.07	0.009	0.51	13.3
Matrix Fairness	0.26	0.001	1.97	15.5	0.07	0.006	0.46	15.5
Preferred level	0.22	0.000	1.72	22.4	0.09	0.000	0.41	22.4
Matrix pref level	0.21	0.002	1.93	13.3	0.06	0.012	0.48	13.3
Sarkozy quote								
Support	0.03	0.500	1.85	-4.9	-0.03	0.253	0.59	-4.9
Fairness	0.05	0.228	1.69	2.7	0.01	0.594	0.51	2.7
Matrix Fairness	0.10	0.192	1.97	5.1	0.02	0.364	0.46	5.1
Preferred level	0.11	0.051	1.72	3.7	0.02	0.544	0.41	3.7
Matrix pref level	0.07	0.284	1.93	5.0	0.02	0.345	0.48	5.0

Notes: This table displays the treatment effects of both quotes on the five individual variables measuring support. Each variable is coded as a dummy equal to 1 if the participant selected the most anti-tax option. The first column displays the regression coefficients β^P and β^S, and the second one the p-value testing the null that the coefficient is zero. The third column shows the amount of people who selected the most anti-tax option in the control group; for example, 40% of people in the control group said that they "Completely opposed" the tax. The last column shows the size of the treatment effect in percents, i.e., the ratio of the first column over the third column.

Back to Section 4.2

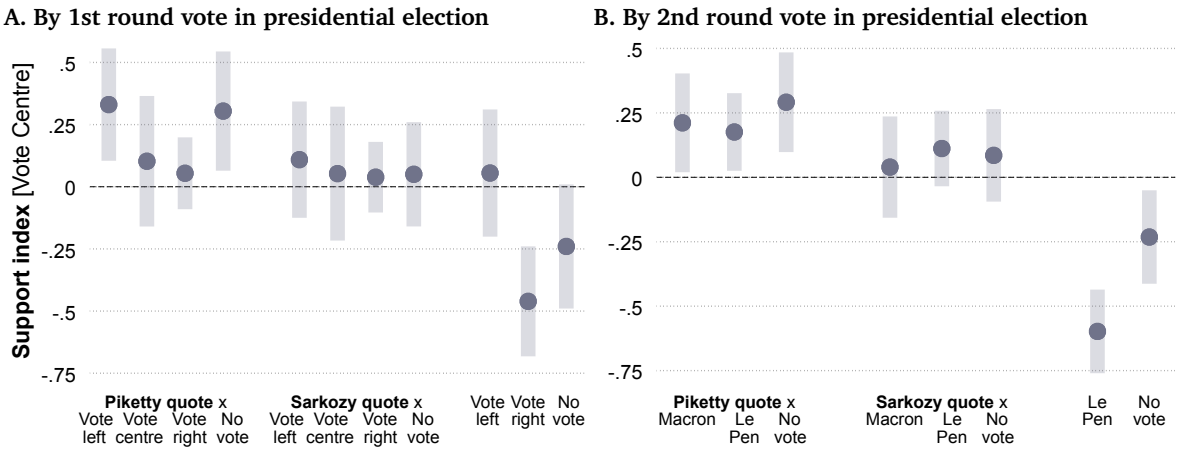
Figure A19: Comparing treatment effects to similar studies



Notes: Each graph depicts, in blue-grey, the main treatments effects of the paper mentioned, and in orange, the effect of this project's treatments (reading the Piketty or the Sarkozy quote) using the same outcome variable and the same set of controls as said paper. For example, in Panel B, instead of the support index used throughout, the outcome variable is a dumy equal to one if the participant does not oppose the inheritance tax (on a Likert scale going from Completely oppose to Completely support).

Back to Section 4.2

Figure A20: Treatment effects by political affiliation



Notes: This graph shows the treatment effects of the two quotes interacted with political behaviour. Individuals in Panel A are categorised based on their behaviour in the 1st round of the 2022 presidential election; they voted left if they voted for Nathalie Arthaud, Anne Hidalgo, Yannick Jadot, Jean-Luc Mélenchon, Philippe Poutou, or Fabien Roussel; centre if they voted for Jean Lassalle, Emmanuel Macron, or Valérie Pécresse; and right if they voted for Nicolas Dupont-Aignan, Marine Le Pen, or Éric Zemmour. The reference category is control individuals who voted for the centre in Panel A, and control Macron voters in Panel B. Baseline controls are included, and 95% confidence intervals are displayed.

Back to Section 4.3

B Survey structure

This section provides further detail about the survey structure

B.1 Demographics

This section collects data on the participants' gender, age, *département* of residence, net household income, net household wealth, marital status, number of siblings, household composition, and family structure.

B.2 Perceptions section

The perceptions section collects data on mechanisms that could explain support for the tax but that aren't directly related to the tax itself (those are included in the Tax section, see infra). The goal was to not prime respondents who saw this section first to think about the inheritance tax before they were shown the open-ended question. The section included questions about a) education level and parent's education level, employment status, sector, and job title, b) experienced social mobility ("How do you feel your status/income compares to your parents"), expected net wealth at age 75, c) self-reported political affiliation and voting behaviour in the 2022 presidential election, d) perceptions of equality of opportunity, approval of government decisions, capacity of the government to improve equality of opportunity, e) importance of a range of values, and f) optimism/pessimism regarding future social mobility (of their children compared to themselves if the participants have children, of themselves compared to their parents if they don't).

B.3 Open-ended question

The open-ended question reads: "The inheritance tax, also called "succession duty" is a tax collected by the state on the transfer of wealth from a deceased person to their heirs. Can you describe in a few sentences what this tax brings to your mind?". Participants are provided with a text field in which they can write as much or as little as they want. This question is always asked before any treatment happens.

The text data collected is then processed in several steps:

(1) I first remove capitalisation, numbers, symbols, diacritics[20], and punctuation, to the exception of exclamation marks and question marks, which are informative about an answer's sentiment. Stopwords are also removed: those are words that are very common but don't carry much meaning, such as "this", "for", "my"; finally, words present in the question that are often repeated by respondents, such as "tax" and "inheritance" are removed as well.

(2) Each word is then lemmatised, that is, mapped to its "root word", or lemma; for example, *agreement*, *agreed*, *agreeing* all map to *to agree*. That step is crucial as it allows to reduce the number of unique words and the extreme sparsity of the data.

(3) Individual words are then combined into 1-, 2-, and 3-grams; that is, each answer is attributed the unique lemmas it contains, as well as the combinations of two and three lemmas

[20] Accents are meaningful in French, and allow to distinguish between words that are not necessarily synonyms; but they are also often misused by respondents, who typed without utmost regard to spelling. The amount of incorrectly used accents (omitted or plainly wrong) made it necessary to remove them altogether so words could be recognised by dictionaries and mapped to the right lemmas.

that are at most one word apart; for example, an answer consisting of four words, A B C D, will correspond to the 2-grams AB, AC, BC, BD, and CD, and the 3-grams ABC, ABD, ACD, and BCD. That step allows to identify words that are frequently used together, such as "whole life" or "pay twice".

(4) Where necessary, the data is then translated into English[21].

Although participants were not obliged to answer the open-ended question[22], an overwhelming majority did: as shown in Figure A3, less than 3% of participants chose not to write anything, and over 80% wrote at least 10 characters (excluding spaces). The median answer was 38 characters long. Those descriptives are an encouraging sign that a large majority of participants put effort in answering the survey.

B.4 Measuring support for taxes and Tax section

After answering the open-ended question and possibly reading a treatment quote (the treatment design is presented in detail in Section 1.2 below), participants are asked about their support for the inheritance tax, as well as for other taxes. Specifically, they first see three questions asking them about the inheritance tax:

The main outcome variable used to measure support for the inheritance tax is a standardised index, aggregating five survey questions: three questions asking in isolation about the inheritance tax (Support: How would you describe your support for the current French inheritance tax? [Completely oppose - Completely support] Fairness: How fair do you deem the inheritance tax? [Completely unfair - Completely fair] and Preferred level: In your opinion, compared to its current level in France, the inheritance tax should ideally be: [Repealed - Much higher]), plus two additional questions where participants are presented with a matrix, and have to express support for the inheritance tax together with four other taxes (the labour income tax, capital income tax, VAT, and fuel tax). The first question asks them to rate the fairness of each tax (Matrix Fairness: How fair do you think it is to tax the following resources? [Completely unfair - Completely fair]), the second is about each tax ideal level (Matrix Preferred level: In your opinion, what should be the level of the following taxes, compared to their current level in France? [Repealed - Much higher]).

(1) **Support**: "How would you describe your support for the current French inheritance tax?" Answers range from Completely oppose to Completely support on a 5-point Likert scale.

(2) **Fairness**: "How fair do you deem the inheritance tax?" Answers range from Completely unfair to Completely fair on a 5-point Likert scale.

(3) **Preferred level**: "In your opinion, compared to its current level in France, the inheritance tax should ideally be:" Answers range from Repealed to Much higher on a 6-point Likert scale.

[21] On step (4), note that the original data being in French then translated creates some ambiguities. For example, the French word for *[a] person* and *nobody* is the same (*personne*). When translating, one of the translations has to be picked — which is done on the basis of having carefully read all answers several times, and getting a feel for the context those words are generally used in. 2- and 3-grams are less of a concern, as the words are grouped with their neighbours and can be translated more accurately; but some nuances in the 1-grams will unfortunately be lost in translation.

[22] The whole survey, apart from the consent form, worked as follows: if the participant skipped a question and tried to move to the next page, a message appeared, warning her that one of the questions was left unanswered; but she could just close that warning and move on with the rest of the questionnaire.

On the next page, they are asked one (randomly picked) additional version of the Fairness question, which is either one of the following:

(1) **Fairness wealthy inherited**: "Is it fair or unfair that wealthy parents who have inherited a large estate from their parents are subject to the inheritance tax?" Answers range from Completely unfair to Completely fair on a 5-point Likert scale.

(2) **Fairness wealthy worked hard**: "Is it fair or unfair that wealthy parents who have worked hard and saved a lot to pass on their wealth to their children are subject to the inheritance tax?" Answers range from Completely unfair to Completely fair on a 5-point Likert scale.

It is worth noting that those questions specify both a high level of wealth ("wealthy parents") and the origin of that wealth (inheritance or hard work).

On the next page, they are asked their opinion on the inheritance tax along with four other taxes, labeled as follows: the labour income tax (wages); the capital income tax (rents, dividends); the value added tax (VAT); the fuel tax. Here they are faced with two questions, presented in a matrix, with one tax per row:

(1) **Matrix fairness**: "In general, do you believe it is fair or unfair to tax the following resources?" Answers range from Completely unfair to Completely fair on a 7-point Likert scale.

(2) **Matrix preferred level**: "In your opinion, what should the level of the following taxes be, compared to their current level in France?" Answers range from Repealed to Much higher on a 7-point Likert scale.

Next, participants are shown (in a random order) the last three blocks of questions in the Tax section; the knowledge block, asking them how confident they are about their knowledge of the tax, then about the tax exemption threshold and top tax rate for a transfer from a parent to a child; the equity-efficiency block, asking them whether they believe taxes rather hinder economic activity or ensure social and economic equity, whether various socio-economic categories would rather lose or gain if the inheritance tax were cut, and whether an increase in the inheritance tax would rather encourage or slow down economic activity; and lastly the incidence block, where they are asked whether they expect to leave and/or to receive a substantial inheritance, whether they have already received a bequest or a donation, whether they have already made a donation, whether they ever had to pay the inheritance tax, and whether they have written a will.

Note that this whole section always takes place after treatment for treated individuals.

B.5 Attention check

The attention check is a "trap" question that is unrelated to the survey's topic, and aims to test whether participants read questions carefully. In this survey, the attention check was phrased as follows:

"The next question is about the following problem. In questionnaires like ours, some participants sometimes do not carefully read the questions and just click through the survey distractedly. This means ending up with a lot of random answers that compromise the results of research studies. To show that you do read questions attentively, please select all four options below, no matter your opinion; then move on with the rest of the survey. What do you think motivates politicians to run for office?".

The choices offered were “Willingness to serve their nation”, “Prestige and power”, “Material profit”, and “None of the above”. More details about the attention check and how it was used to detect careless respondents are provided in Section 1.3.1.

B.6 Feedback

The last section asked participants whether they felt that the survey was unbiased, left-wing or right-wing biased, and provided a text field for additional comments.